ESDF - part 01: First Captain of the Etherian Space Defence Force

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32215192.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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by Skyinou

Summary

Not so long after Prime's defeat, Entrapta manages to take control over a few of his spaceships. While the Best Friend Squad is waiting for Darla to be repaired, Etheria's new defence unit is preparing to use those ships. When a second test flight is successful, therefore uneventful, Glimmer tasks Lonnie to take a squad and investigate Prime's flagship that Adora turned into a giant floating tree.

Notes

Hi there!

After ten more-or-less serious but feelings-heavy works in this series, I offer you a lighter eleventh piece!
A few OCs to fill Lonnie's squad, lots of banters and silliness.
You have been warned!

I hope you'll enjoy it as well!

See the end of the work for more notes

Prologue: Previously on Etheria

Previously in this fanfic!

After Prime's defeat, everything quickly calmed down on Etheria but all the kingdoms are still busy rebuilding. Catra and Adora live in Bright Moon's castle with Glimmer and Bow who's now *prince* since he's officially to marry the queen one day. Micah lives also there but tries to be discreet to let his daughter rule by herself. He does advise though, and is often seen in the castle with general Juliet doing all kinds of background tasks for the kingdom that the queen has not enough time for.

To celebrate the end of the war, a day was chosen to organise big parties all over Etheria three weeks after, with one gathering all of the princesses and other representatives of every kingdom. This party took place in Frosta's palace and it developed as most parties do: lots of fun, food, some trouble, fizzy drinks, a little crazy as the night goes on, and with a hazy morning the day after.

In the meantime, there's a lot of healing to do for everyone and more than ever comfort and tender words are needed all around. However, since they have earned some peace and quiet, most people have the opportunity to do so, with the help of friends or family; both if they are lucky.

Glimmer has hired Catra as *Intendant* of Bright Moon, a long unused title that lets the queen give the feline girl pretty much any task she wants, making the best of her management skills while the pink-haired leader focuses on diplomacy. There obviously was some reticence from the people around and Catra herself, but Glimmer knows how to get what she wants.

Kyle, Rogelio and Lonnie also moved in Bright Moon, in a new district specially built to mix ex-Horde members with other Etherian's inhabitants. The queen has decided that the best way to get over the war is to force people to face that both sides were mostly just that: *people*.

Catra is still trying to reconnect with those *friends* that she ignored and abandoned in the past. She managed to have Lonnie turn around mostly, but the two men are still not really in talking terms with the feline girl. However, they all decided to not lose sleep over this and let it go, since they want to spend time with Adora, who Catra comes as a pair with.

Kyle found a job that interests him very much, creating little figurines for an old shop, whose owner considers Kyle's upbringing in the Etherian's Horde as a positive *new perspective*. Rogelio is currently working as a carpenter since he discovered that he appreciates wood very much and the job is needed a lot with all the reconstruction going on.

Glimmer also hired Lonnie to train a new small professional army to protect Etheria from the outside world. It's supposed to be in service of the whole Princess Alliance, not only Bright Moon, and other princesses won't forget to remind the queen of that. With the help of Entrapta, they are gradually taking control over the ships that Prime's Horde left behind. When Lonnie realised that she could command a ship and fly through space, she also took a second role, becoming the first captain of this new unit named Etheria Space Defence Force.

Her first mission is to investigate if there's anything salvageable from the Velvet Glove after what Adora did to it. When everything is ready, about two weeks after the end-of-war big parties, she leaves Etheria's surface with her squad, Entrapta and Bright Moon's intendant.

The ESDF's first trip

“Captain’s log 0-0-4. We just took off from Bright Moon. Destination: Prime’s flagship, that apparently Adora turned into a tree… I’m not sure I believe that one. Anyway, we need to assess the situation and-” Lonnie tries to stay serious as she records the events.

“Are you really doing that?” snickers Catra.

Lonnie grumbles. “Queen’s order. What are you even doing here anyway?”

“Queen’s order…” Catra shrugs and the other woman sighs.

“I’m gonna punch her one of these days!” Lonnie’s words make Catra laugh. The captain closes the recording software and pushes the ship’s internal communication switch. “Snip, Silkya, Miriann! Get your asses up here!”

“I’m already here, captain...” A nonchalant voice comes from the wall to which Catra was leaning against. A part of said wall moves and a little man reveals himself. When in motion, the patterns drawn on his clothes make him very much noticeable, and ridiculous, but immobile like earlier, they were so perfectly complementing the metal panel behind him that he was literally invisible.

Catra jumps away. “Why the stars are you camouflaging yourself *inside* the ship?!”

“You never know…” says the man as he turns around and takes a few steps away, visibly annoyed by Catra’s surprise.

Lonnie sighs again but she is apparently used to his weird antics. Catra stares at him some more. That camouflage can only be used inside this one ship, probably against this one wall, which makes it arguably useless, but he doesn’t seem to have a problem with that at all.

“Snip? That’s his name?” She inquires to Lonnie, more as a mean to prevent an awkward silence than real curiosity, but the man faces her again.

“Because I’m like this.” He gestures at his own eyes, then far away, and at his eyes once more, which look completely normal by the way.

“It’s supposed to explain anything?”

“Probably.”

“Don’t try to have a conversation with him, it’s futile.” interrupts a tall woman as she enters the bridge. She looks more like the scholar type with her demeanour and the way she carries the stack of documents in her hands yet she is almost as muscular as She-Ra.

Snip shrugs and steps away again. “Nobody understands me… I wish there was someone called *Nobody*...”

“Who’s the kitty?” Another woman’s head appears from behind the taller one and she asks this as she points at Catra, of course.

The feline girl flinches but tries to stay calm and composed for now. This one is as short as her and very slender, but… ‘she probably is stronger than she looks’ Catra ponders when she notices the sword on her back. The very big sword, that would surely make Adora jealous, almost as tall as the woman who carries it, and almost a foot wide. Catra silently scoffs. She is quite knowledgable about fighting herself, and while her claws may lack in reach, this oversized weapon seems a lot more ridiculous in all kind of ways. And that’s not even taking into account the woman’s long platinum blonde hair waving around untied, that doesn’t seem fit for combat either.

“I’m Bright Moon Intendant Catra, which makes me your superior too…” Catra tries to put the recruit subtly back in her place.

"Oh! Righty. Miri told me something 'bout that. Recruit Silkya here! Nice to meet ya!" Silkya stands a little straighter but doesn't put much more effort to look particularly respectful.

Lonnie looks half way between anger and despair as she sighs once more. "Guys, remember how we talked about having someone inspect what we are doing today? Well, that's now, and I know you are all past being *recruits* as far as experience goes but can I have a little more serious here?!"

"Aye Capt'n!" answers Silkya with enough enthusiasm to not sound ashamed whatsoever and while she does stand at attention she doesn't hide a half grin lifting the corner of her mouth.

Catra glances at Lonnie, who begins to lecture the smaller woman on the benefit of discipline and order in a military squad, yet Snip seems to feel more concerned by it than Silkya next to him. Catra turns around to hide a smirk and laughter and she spots the first taller woman looking at the stars outside while studying a weird map. At least this woman seems normal.

"So I suppose you are *Miri*?"

"The name's Miriann. Please don't shorten it as Silk does." She barely takes her eyes away from the stars and documents.

"What are you doing?"

"Trying to figure when we are."

"You mean *where* we are?"

"No."

Catra doesn't insist, feeling like she might catch *craziness* if she tries to understand this bunch of people too much. The last member of the team is a minotaur, currently piloting the ship.

"And the big guy?" she asks Lonnie when the captain finally lets Silkya and Snip go free from her lecture.

“Shyko? What about him?”

“He hasn’t said a word since we left.”

“Yeah, at least *he* is quiet.” Lonnie stares at the pair of strange women who started to talk loudly together as soon as the short one joined the tall one by the window.

Shyko slowly turns his head and nods to acknowledge Catra’s presence, humming slightly, and with no hurry at all, faces forward again. It doesn’t seem like piloting is taking much of his attention though. With his appearance, his calm and his way of looking slow, it feels like he would belong very much more in a green field of grass rather than at the helm of a spaceship. Catra refrains from voicing out the feeling however, this might be quite a rude thing to say to a minotaur.

And for now, she doesn’t want trouble. Sparkles tasked her to observe how this little squad is performing and while she doesn’t really want to be here, she intends to do her job properly. But so far she doesn’t know what to think of them.

“Your team is weird.” she remarks to Lonnie.

“I didn’t choose them for their social skills…”

“Yeah, what did you choose them for then?” snickers Catra. She knows that Lonnie is good at training and judging recruits so if she chose them, she must have a reason, however this reason seems quite obscure at the moment.

“Out of all the recruits I’m in charge of, I’m confident they are the only ones who are ready to get out there. Except for the social part… but that shouldn’t matter today. Most others are too young and new to all this because most of the seasoned fighters left this line of work to start a new life. I asked Glimmer for more time before this mission but she refused. You know her. Weirdly enough, those four were already combat ready when I met them, and they are stunningly good. Also the story of the first test flight

may have calmed down a few others too. I wanted volunteers this time and there weren't many."

"If they know how to fight so well, how come we didn't meet them before?"

"I.. do.. not.. fight. Usually." answers Shyko slowly.

"Oh stars, please don't ask that…" Silkya sighs while the tall woman at her side beams as she prepares to speak.

"Ah, those princesses! You won't believe how elitist they were, or maybe you already know. The *Princess Alliance*. Yeah, sure, they did finally accept other people too at the end because they needed it, or so they say, but five years ago when we wanted to join? Noooo, you had to have the title or special powers to even request a meeting! Why couldn't I be a princess, you may ask? Our stupid kingdom has this stupid rule… And I know I've been banned from using magic, but-"

"Wait, what?" interrupts Catra.

"Okay, I know it sounds bad, but really, my magic is just a little wild every times I end up in a world where there already is magic-"

"*A little*, yeah!" Silkya shortly laughs loudly. "She blew up a building trying to light a candle! Mystacor's headmaster threw her out!"

"You are not from this world?!" exclaims Catra.

"Yes, we are, *this time around*… it's a little complicated?"

"Wait until she tells you why she couldn't be a princess!" Silkya laughs again.

"No, no. That's not necessary!" answer both Catra and Miriann in sync. The feline girl glances at the tall woman, then looks back at

the short one questioningly and that is enough to entice the latter to give more details, despite the former's protest.

"When she came back from training in Mystacor, she put her name on the list to be a candidate for the next princess election…" She pauses to create a more dramatic effect. "She was politely rejected, and laughed at, because she was too old!"

"You could have told me before I ridiculed myself! You knew!" erupts Miriann.

"Yep, a very nice memory indeed!" replies Silkya instantly, looking very much more smug than apologetic, and an instant later Miriann grunts and starts chasing her around the bridge.

"QUIET!" commands Lonnie, and the two running women stop right in their track, showing that they *can* obey orders when needed, or when they want; Catra isn't certain yet.

There is a brief moment of complete silence in the room, however something is bugging the feline girl. "And so, about being from this world but not from this world?" For some reason she can't seem to let the subject go.

Lonnie sighs once again. "Don't encourage her, please. She can *literally* talk about it for days."

"But it's true! Silkya and me have already lived a few lives in different worlds!"

"Hu, okay..." Catra is starting to wonder if Lonnie hasn't turned crazy herself and chose the wrong people.

"Siiiilk! They don't believe me!" whines Miriann like a little kid. "Why?! I understand when we end up somewhere people don't believe in magic, but here..."

"Yes, yes, Miri, but we are approaching the BFT, so shut up for now." replies Silkya suddenly all serious.

“The what?” Catra has to ask.

“The Big F- hmm, *floating* Tree!” Silkya’s effort to avoid the *F word* makes Miriann laugh but she soon switches mood to match the shorter woman’s seriousness as she puts away her weird looking map.

“Here she goes giving things weird names again…” grunts Lonnie.

“But it makes things easier! Like we all are now in the ESDF and my weapon is a BFS!” Silkya winks as she points at her uniform and sword but all she gets is an annoyed glare from Lonnie and a scoff from Catra at the last particular abbreviation. Silkya only now accounting for the fact that they could have numerous different meanings decides to give more details again. “It’s a Big F- … shit, I’ve got no replacement word for this *F*! Well, Big Sword. You see why abbreviation are better? I can’t say BS though, because that would be bull-” She cuts herself and sighs. “Urg. It just works, okay?”

Catra is laughing by the end of Silkya’s unhelping explanation but for the most part it isn’t for the short woman’s silliness. She will have to tell all about this use of the F in the BFS abbreviation to Sparkles and Bow later!

“Why are you so adamant not to use the *F* word today?” inquires Miriann.

“Hee? But there’s a kid here!” replies Silkya as she points at Catra who doesn’t hide her irritation.

Lonnie sighs heavily and hides her face with a hand. “Just shut up, Silk! And Catra, please ignore her...”

Entrapta erupts on the bridge, conjuring a global silence out of the others’ curiosity, and hastily types a few commands on the main keyboard. “We are not alone.”

“We already knew there were other people in the universe?” answers Silkya naively.

“I mean there is another ship close!”

“There are still a lot of Prime’s ships left around Etheria, you said earlier.” replies Silkya out of point again.

“There is a NOT Prime’s ship docked to the other side of the Velvet Glove right now!” explodes Entrapta quite annoyed.

Despite Snip snickering at the exchange, the team focuses on a last check that everything is ready. While they didn’t think they would meet people from outside Etheria so soon, it is what they signed for after all.

Crazy land

Catra has heard stories about the last time an Etherian crew boarded Prime's flagship. While most of them still make her shiver, there is one part that always warms her heart. It was very dangerous and Adora still did it to save *just* her. Sparkles did too. And recently, Catra has come to appreciate the fact that Bow, being the only non-magical non-princess of the group, was also ready to brave all those dangers. Maybe not for her sake directly, but to support Adora's decision to save her. Also Sparkles had no access to magic either at the time and Adora thought she had lost She-Ra, yet they still came nonetheless.

But the people telling those stories almost always accentuate the technical details of the operation. Entrapta because she is Entrapta, and the others because they don't want to dwell too much on the other parts of the story involved, even more so in front of Catra...

While Entrapta is the only one having taken part of both last time and now, today they don't have to ruse their way in, so she is already focused on her science. Which is both reassuring and more than a little worrying since she is easily sidetracked by the way, and space is still dangerous, and being struck by magic certainly didn't make the ship stable, and they just learnt that there are other people inside.

Despite the giant tree, the ship's power source is still online and the energy shield around it seems functional as well, therefore they will be able to simply fly inside a ship bay and normally disembark and have oxygen. But two questions are burning Catra's lips.

"Is the attraction thing… the *gravity* still working too?" She had an unsettling experience without gravity aboard Darla and right now she doesn't want any added uneasiness.

"Yes!" answers the princess as enthusiastic as ever.

"No fun!" whines Miriann, letting her serious expression drop for a second and a half.

"As if you didn't have enough fun last time with your Jav' suit flying around!" intervenes Silkya.

"But there still *was* gravity!"

"Oh, come on! You chose that suit *only* because you could almost hover indefinitely, regardless of what else it could do!"

Catra growls lowly. She didn't expect finding herself around Lonnie's clones, serious and obedient soldiers, but those two are a lot less focused than the worst she imagined, and her patience is running low. While their stories have some kind of entertaining appeal, she can't help but compare them to Sea Hawk's tales… and that's not a compliment, in this context, at least, if ever…

Silkya throws a glance at Catra and straightens up, regaining some serious, then abruptly shoves an elbow into Miriann's side to make her follow. The two of them clear their throats. "Please, go on."

Catra snarls and grunts but ultimately turns to Entrapta again. She will have to deal with the other two women later, right now they have more important matters to tend to. "Are there still clones and robots inside?"

"No clones! Prime sent all of them to the surface at the end of the battle. I can't tell about robots until I'm connected to the network inside, though!" answers Entrapta energetically again.

Catra sighs in relief. She really doesn't want to deal with strangers *and* disoriented clones at the same time. There was the briefest of time in the past when she thought she could understand Prime, but really that didn't last. Yet amongst the little she did understand, is that behind his apparent smooth moderation, he didn't do things halfway. An *all-out assault* was literal. They will probably find clones scattered all over the galaxy but not likely

around Etheria as all clones in range were sent to the surface of the planet.

After a short battle with the schematics showing on her trackpad's screen, Entrapta gives a few directions to Shyko to a safe place to enter the Velvet Glove and *land*. The minotaur, until then so calm, starts to sweat a little at the narrowness of the spot he is supposed to fly into. Nobody is voicing it aloud, but he can't have more than a few days of practice behind him, and while flying in the emptiness of space is forgiving, parking into a hole not even twice as wide as the ship itself is not.

"Didn't you learn to pilot a ship in one of your previous lives?" blurts out Catra to Silkya and Miriann as she becomes even more nervous herself.

"It… doesn't work like that." reply both women in sync.

Of course it doesn't. What was she thinking… Catra gasps. Is she seriously beginning to believe their nonsense?! Adora is the naive one, not her! She growls her frustration away in a corner and Lonnie starts giving orders for her team to disembark as soon as they dock and be ready for anything, in case there is a welcoming committee. Catra's nervousness and focus are swiftly redirected at the mission. If they managed to detect another ship with their low understanding of all this tech, no offence to Entrapta intended, the other ship probably did the same. And themselves just arrived in a Horde ship, which probably isn't a friendly sight to most of the universe.

Before leaving the bridge, Lonnie types a message for Bright Moon about that first discovery, however Catra sees her hesitate to push the *send* button. Lonnie shrugs and notices that Catra is still here, looking at her questioningly.

"You know how Glimmer will react, right?" says Lonnie flatly. "I mean, I'm pretty sure she can't teleport this far, but she will do whatever she can to come here or send She-Ra. With no regard about if we actually manage the mission on our own or not."

Catra offers a friendly smile for once. She can't say she doesn't empathise with this. How many times did she try to do things herself, only to have Adora swoop by to meddle and take care of them in her place. But today is bigger than this, and Lonnie knows it, and ultimately pushes the button, before hurrying Catra along to join the others.

Entrapta distributes communication earpieces to everyone and makes a few awkward recommendations about how to handle the tech on Prime's flagship.

"You seem to have learnt to *handle* her pretty well too." snickers Catra to Lonnie.

"I could have done without the hassle of having to stop her from calling Shyko *Mister Cow*…" The girl shrugs once more. She will definitely need a good massage to eliminate all that tension and frustration after this mission.

"And you didn't stop Silkya from calling me *kitty*?"

"I think I'm gonna allow that one. Maybe even support it!" scoffs Lonnie, as she puts on her combat harness and grabs an energy beam hand cannon that Catra recognises. "Now focus. You are with me; we'll escort Entrapta and Miriann to the main server room. Shyko stays here to guard the ship, Silkya and Snip are on recon duty."

The landing is almost smooth. Almost. But somehow everyone still prays a silent little thank you to the new pilot. The door is barely open and the ramp still extending that Snip's voice startles Catra. She has very good eyes, and yet *she* didn't have enough time to really glimpse outside.

"Clear."

The team gets out quickly and the first door opens automatically as they approach. Entrapta seems to have done a good job to find a safe place to land because this hangar is clean, but the next corridor is partly demolished by a few tree branches and as they

advance that seems to be the norm. Lonnie looks more closely at the plant and her face's expression goes from awe to fear to finally a smile. The tree seems real enough. So Adora really did turn the ship into a giant floating tree, not just an illusion of it.

"Okay, this way!" Entrapta jumps ahead while looking mostly at her trackpad, rather than her feet.

But as usual, helped by her hair, she is more agile than she looks and doesn't seem hindered by the branches and roots in her way. Lonnie catches with her quickly but doesn't even try to slow her down and Catra promptly does the same, Miriann in her steps. But the tall woman briefly looks back and Catra can't help but glances out of curiosity, and the feline girl catches her sweetly blowing a kiss to Silkya with a playful smile before looking straight ahead again. Sensing that Catra has seen her, Miriann then winks and puts a finger to her own lips to invite Catra to stay silent about it.

Catra winces. She is starting to feel like she is surrounded by crazy carefree, reckless and brave-stupid people again. "I'm going to die… nine lives won't be enough with these people!" She grumbles as she pulls her hair in frustration, thinking of how Netossa usually jokes about her having multiple lives since *she's a cat* or something. However, with their communication earpieces, even her mumbling is clearly heard by the entire team.

"You have multiple lives too?!" exclaims Silkya.

Miriann sighs dramatically as she runs and takes her head in a hand. "Silk, she is talking about her nine *cat* lives, as in the myth."

"Oh? Oh…"

"You really are out of common sense this time around!"

"Come oooon, gimme some slack," answers Silkya in a growl. "Last three loops were all *end of the world* kinda things! And this one wasn't far from turning that way too one month ago! You can't blame me for losing touch at *normal*!"

“What’s a *month*?” inquire Catra and Lonnie.

“Right. They don’t have those here.” Silkya sighs. “I’ll keep it simple. More or less thirty days. Makes me remember they don’t even have weekend either! Miri, how can you stay so sane all the times?!”

“No, no, it’s easy, you’re just bad at it!” laughs Miriann.

“But they have the same myth about cats! The universe’s randomness is killing me!”

“Oh please don’t die yet!” replies Miriann hastily but with mirth. “I wanna live a little longer in *this* world! We didn’t save it so far!”

“*I* sure did!” interrupts Catra, more than a little happy to get an easy retort. *Easy*. She realises that at least their stupidity helps to keep her head out of dreadful thoughts. “Do you have some kind of *hero complex* like Adora too?” snickers Catra. She knows that her blonde girlfriend trains with the recruits in the morning so they should know her.

“Hurg… no.” The tall woman sighs and looks at her almost with despair in her eyes. “It’s more like destiny doesn’t want to leave us alone! Almost every times, we are reborn in a world that needs saving!”

Catra shrugs once again. Why did she even ask further into this nonsense... To make things worse, Silkya and Miriann begin to bicker about who saved the most worlds up until now or whatever.

“Riiight! Don’t listen to her, kitt- *Intendant Catra*,” adds Silkya. “She turns it into a competition every chances she gets! You have no idea how jealous she is of Adora and you!”

“I’m not! You’re the one always trying to push me on the sideline!” whines Miriann.

‘Are they serious right now?’ Catra is ready to explode and yell.

Suddenly, a few steps ahead, Lonnie grabs Entrapta and pulls her against a wall for safety. “Shh! Someone’s here!” she whispers strongly enough to shut up the unruly bunch, and Catra and Miriann also swiftly hug the opposite wall, eyes sharp and directed at the far end of the hallway.

The contact of the metal panel against her back is cold and Catra freezes. She shouldn’t have come. The absence of clone helps but it’s still the place where most of her worst memories happened. She spent days pacing these corridors, days wondering where she went wrong, how to fix things, how to survive, and later even how to save Sparkles. Save Adora. And almost died for it. And got chipped. And then paced these same hallways while not being really in control of her own body and mind... Why did she think she could come here without trouble?!

Encounter

Catra's heart starts to race and her legs become wobbly. However, she feels something gently drawing circles on her lower back. The gesture grounds her enough to the present to get her mind working and she remembers that recent time when she was waiting for Adora in front of the Ice Palace in the same kind of situation. She focuses on her breathing with a little help of one of Perfuma's exercises and this time thankfully she isn't too late to stop the spiral.

"Hey, hmm, hu, miss Intendant, is everything alright?" asks Miriann with a weird hesitant expression.

"I'm fine! Can't you tell?!" blurts out Catra hysterically between two raspy breaths. What kind of stupid question is that?! She's obviously *not* fine but just as much obviously going to deny it when asked this way, or ever.

"What's wrong with her?" inquires Silkya through their earpieces.

"Oh, shit!" exclaims Lonnie as she notices Catra's very pale face and trembling body.

"Who's there?" An unknown male voice resonates through the hallway.

Catra concentrates on her breathing again. She has to get through this before anything else but she feels very weak. She vaguely hears Lonnie answering loudly to the other party that they are from Etheria, and Lonnie actually has to explain *what Etheria is*, and the exchange that follows is soon stuck on both sides refusing to give any detail about who they really are while asking the other to be more precise. That at least gives her some time.

One. Breathe in. Two. Three. Breathe out. Four. Five. *Kitty*. She isn't a monster anymore, she deserve better than being harassed by Prime's ghost. One. Breathe in. Two. Three. Breathe out. Four.

Five. *Kitty*. She isn't a frail animal either. She can overcome this. She already confronted people who hate her and people she hurt, places she destroyed and places that hurt her. That was more difficult and dreadful than this. One. Breathe in. Two. Three. Breathe out. Four. Five.

Her heart calms down and thankfully her strength comes back instantly. *Kitty*. She feels small and she leans against the hand on her back ever so slightly, the contact helping her think more clearly. If only it was Adora's hand, and she imagines it is. *Kitty*. But somehow she doesn't want her princess to be here because Adora would probably make that face she does when she is sorry and crushed by the weight of the stupid responsibilities she thinks she has to bear. *Kitty*.

"Kitty. Kitty, kitty kitty kitty-"

"Shut up Silkya!!" explodes Catra when she realises that it isn't her mind playing tricks on her but the blonde woman whispering through her earpiece.

"Yes ma'am!" Silkya answers cheerfully.

"I'm going to kill you later!"

"Please don't, I don't want to-" intervenes Miriann but Catra interrupts her.

"You shut up too!"

"What's going on?" echoes the male voice louder from the other side of the corridor.

"Nothing that concerns you." answers Lonnie just as loud and she sighs again. "Shall we meet up so we can stop shouting like idiots now?"

The man chuckles dryly. "Not yet, I'm afraid."

"I told you, we are from Etheria-"

“Right. From a system that doesn’t appear on any map, where the Horde suddenly diverted a noticeable size of its resources. And you just happen to travel in a Horde spaceship by chance. And just happen to come to its flagship to admire the view, with said ship that just happens to be mysteriously abandoned and infested by this… nonsensical tree!”

“Since the Horde is done for, we salvaged the little ships. We are here to investigate if we can do the same with this one.”

“Done for? What the hell are you talking about?”

“You don’t know that Prime has been defeated?”

“Bullshit! That’s impossible!”

“How else could we be here freely aboard his flagship? We killed him thirty days ago, more or less.” After those words, there is a lot of muttering at the other end of the corridor. “You good?” Lonnie asks Catra in a whisper and the feline girl nods convincingly enough.

They then exchange a questioning look with Miriann and Entrapta. Did Prime’s fall really go that unnoticed? However, the former simply shrugs to communicate her lack of present knowledge and the latter has her full attention caught by her trackpad. Lonnie managed to make her understand that it was better for her to not talk right now, therefore she is doing whatever science she can from the tool.

Lonnie and Catra take both a deep breath. It’s not like they know a lot about the universe outside Etheria either, and for all they *do* know, the planet has been hidden for a thousand years, so suddenly coming out and convince people that they have defeated the Horde, which has reigned for *they-don’t-know-how-long*, will probably be a challenge.

Lonnie tries another angle. “We are not chipped. We can show you our necks if you want.” For now she needs to at least get the conversation going in order to gather informations.

“Chipped? You mean, controlled by the Horde?”

“Yes.” There’s another round of whispering amongst the other party, and another questioning look between Lonnie and Catra.

“Haven’t seen a *chip* in twenty years or so. You must really have pissed the Horde off if they used them on your people. Usually they just give you the choice of obeying or be destroyed.”

“Well, yeah, we do have some people really good at pissing you off.” blurts out Lonnie, looking at Catra and thinking about the queen just as much. “More seriously, is there any way you will let us pass? We need to go to the server room.”

“That will be difficult without some kind of proof that you are not a threat to us.”

“Would a proof of Prime’s death help? His body should still be down from the command platform where he got shot.” Lonnie did her homework. She has come prepared and knowing everything that happened in this ship that they know of, from Glimmer’s time in prison to Entrapta convincing Hordak to rebel, passing by Catra’s rescue. The only part she doesn’t know exactly is Catra’s version of that last one, because she really didn’t want to ask. And she didn’t have to force herself since she learnt that Catra was going to be here too. There is a minute of silence after some more far whispering.

“We found the body. And my science guy seems to agree that thirty or so days ago, everything stopped inside the Horde’s network. But you should know that Horde Prime can switch bodies.”

“You have a science guy? I really want to compare our data!” exclaims Entrapta before Lonnie can shut her up. Explaining to Entrapta that science will have to wait until both teams trust the other somewhat, if it even comes to that, might be a challenge on its own.

"We are aware." She resumes. "But he died down on the planet where his mind was destroyed. Not much we can do to prove that part, wouldn't you agree?"

"Fair enough." Another short silence. "Can you explain that giant tree?"

"Explain what? One of our magic-wielding warrior did it, obviously. Don't ask why a tree… she likes nature and green, I guess." That probably was a little stupid to say but Lonnie has not yet wrapped her head around why Adora did this instead of blowing the ship out of the sky herself, to be honest.

"Magic? Sure, and I'm Santa Claus!!" This time it's not mumbling nor whispers, but laughters that come from the other side.

Lonnie looks at Catra questioningly again but it's Catra's turn to shrug, clueless. However, Miriann glances at them, amused, then snickers and speaks up. "We don't have that myth here. But yeah, we do have magic. The whole package. Fireball, lightning, teleportation, you name it!"

"Ah ah ah, right. Can you prove it?"

"Not that far from the planet-"

"How convenient!" More laughters. "Oh god, what a bunch of clowns. Our first good catch in a year and we have to stumble upon this. You seem harmless enough, though. Crazy, but harmless. Okay, we go to the server room *together*, but you have to share what you find. Is that acceptable?"

"Hey Boss, you really think they can access the mainframe-"

"Shut up, they don't need to know that *we* can't."

That last exchange wasn't meant to be heard but Catra's hearing *is* better than average after all. At least, having this against the other party should keep them ahead if they need to negotiate, so

they should be safe for now. For the rest, they have weapons. And claws. Catra gives a positive nod to Lonnie.

“Alright. I’m captain Lonnie. What’s your name?”

“You can call me Bob for now.”

Lonnie, Catra and Miriann roll their eyes at his attitude and tone of voice. He doesn’t seem inclined to take them seriously anymore, since they talked about magic. They carefully leave the walls and start walking in his direction, ready for anything.

The man doesn’t have any really remarkable feature. He is on the tall side but nothing that imposing. He is quite muscular but not really more so than Lonnie or Miriann. He has two men beside him, that are just as much not-special. All three are definitely armed, yet again, those weapons don’t seem like much.

Catra and Lonnie exchange a quick knowing glance once more. They might be getting too used to encounter princesses and otherly weird and flashy individuals. If a bunch of random people were to sack the old abandoned warehouses remaining in a far corner of the Fright Zone right now, that’s probably how they would come out and there would be nothing odd about it.

As they approach and can see his face though, his jaw suddenly drops as he stares at Catra. Before long, his two acolytes do the same and one even stumbles back and falls on his ass.

“What- the hell is- this?!” He stutters and would probably be pointing at Catra if he wasn’t stunned by the shock.

“What?!” replies the feline girl annoyed. She knows by now that she might be unique but their reactions are a little too extreme for her taste.

“It- you- can talk?!”

Instantly Catra can understand how Swift Wind feels when he starts talking and that thought surpasses her anger. “Of course I

talk. What are you so surprised for?!”

“First time seeing a non-human sentient species, I guess?” inquires Miriann at the lack of coherent response from the three outsiders, and the leader manages a nod. “What about Horde clones?”

“You consider them as sentient?” His mood considerably sours, and his grip on his weapon tightens.

“Now that they are free from Prime’s control, at least, yes?”

“You might want to consider carefully who you are telling that to. Most people treat them as bots out there. And some would kill you on sight for simply saying this.”

His advice sounds genuine enough seeing how shocked he still looks, but part of the shock probably is about Catra rather than their opinion of the clones, so they can’t be too sure. However, just when they are starting to think that he isn’t part of the people who would *kill them on sight for saying this*, he suddenly takes a step back and stiffens.

“That’s what Etheria is? A bio-lab for some kind of genetic experimentations? Is that why it was hidden?”

To everyone’s astonishment, Miriann’s laughter erupts and echoes loudly in the corridor. “Stars, you would rather think that Catra is the result of an experiment than believe that humans aren’t the only ones out there? Seriously? I can assure you there is quite the diversity!”

“Boss!” exclaims one of the minions suddenly, even more panicked than before, as he points a finger at Entrapta. “It- the hair- it- moved!”

“Oh, yes, I forgot, here is magic!” adds Miriann, still laughing, while Entrapta waves at the new trio with her hair, making them recoil from a second round of shock.

While this plain trio of outsiders is given a little time to recover from their surprise, Catra ponders her options. Seeing that they don't know magic, the princesses would definitely have a big advantage, so any operation down on Etheria's ground shouldn't be a threat from them, even in a moderately large number. Also if they are plainly human and ignorant about other species, she is pretty certain she can neutralise the three of them here by herself before they understand how to fight her. In addition, for all the time they have been talking, there are still only three of them, which means there are probably not that many more aboard the Velvet Glove at the moment.

But if they came here without knowing that Prime was gone, they surely want something of value. She just has to find out *what* to own all the cards.

Friend or foe

One of the good sides of being the centre of attention, even if unwanted, is that Catra has no time to brood over any heavy feeling about the place anymore. As both parties are now walking together, following Entrapta's fast pace along the hallways, the trio of strangers has been staring at Catra all along. For who-knows-what strange reason, it seems that the magic of Entrapta's hair is easier to accept than her own existence.

And while feeling special and being admired may have a certain appeal, it can get old fast when one doesn't care about it. Very fast. She has no idea how Adora bears with this kind of fame everyday. At least these three are now acting pretty tame. Lonnie and herself are trying to make them talk to gather informations about them and the outside world, but the leader is very careful not to reveal much and his two minions are still stuck on the fact that humans are not the only sentient talking species, apparently.

Catra is the one not knowing a lot about the world outside Etheria and yet she feels like it's the other party that has been isolated for a thousand years. She did gather some informations the last time she was aboard the Velvet Glove, but she was searching for anything she could use to get out and that isn't very helpful at the moment. Only Miriann seems to find this situation completely normal but Catra and Lonnie don't want to question her openly in front of these new people for now.

In a same manner, *Bob* is trying to get them to talk and while he doesn't seem to believe most of what they say, they are pretty much answering honestly. The only things they hide are that it's their first or second time out of Etheria and that they have no idea what they are doing. And of course both parties stay vague about why they came to this particular ship at this particular moment, *Curiosity* being the common answer they both use.

They arrive at the main server room to find another scrawny guy waiting for them beside the main console. If Kyle had a twin, he

would be him. Catra winces at some memories and she doesn't need to read Lonnie's mind to understand that she shares her feeling. In addition to their similar looks, this guy too seems to be completely out of place and merely waiting for life to give him a better opportunity. Which worries the two girls quickly because it means this team is not a happy group of friends. They didn't really expect that anyway but things would have been so much easier…

Entrapta gets to work and this new person appears to be the *science guy* that has been mentioned. It's her second time here and she does her best to not be distracted by anything else around. While during the previous visit they kind of set the place on fire and made it explode, it has been rebuilt exactly as before. Prime wasn't big on *originality* after all.

This science guy seems to know what he is doing too, and together with Entrapta, they work their way to unlock a part of the data and controls. It doesn't take long for Entrapta to start calling him Copy-Kyle and he doesn't even try to dissuade her to do so, nor ask why, shrugging it off unenthusiastically.

However, as soon as Entrapta starts talking to him about tech and science, his eyes light up and he becomes all excited as if this is the first time he has someone to speak with. The princess answers just as excitedly, as per usual. They managed to display an impressively big holographic map of the *universe* in the middle of the room, but Miriann and Bob soon snicker after staring at it for a few seconds.

"Can you zoom out?" The tall woman asks Entrapta.

"It's supposed to be the entire universe?" replies Entrapta questioningly.

"Is it now? Or is it what Prime called *the universe*?"

Taken by a doubt, Entrapta furiously types on the console again for a moment, suddenly harbouring a very serious face. The map

gets smaller and smaller, and whole new parts appear around it, until it displays the entire galaxy. She stops to glance at it, before continuing and the cluster of stars gets smaller and smaller in turn, then others appear and galaxies after galaxies are fused together into even bigger systems. The edge of the map finally doesn't fill up with new data anymore and every dots of light are swallowed in the centre.

"What an ego!" exclaims Miriann. "He really wanted to make it look like his empire *was* the universe."

Entrapta reverses the process and the little lights expands from the centre of the map, until the first galaxy shown, the one they live in, fits inside the display again and the princess stares at it with an amazed expression. Apparently, anything more than this is too big for her, for now. And in fact almost everyone in the room is looking just as intently at the show of lights with different looks on their faces. Catra and Lonnie are completely mesmerised, while the two minions seem to find it more ordinary but still impressive.

Bob on the other hand doesn't seem to care and Copy-Kyle has taken Entrapta's place typing on the console, and various informations start to appear on the map. Names, sustainability of life in the different systems, their inhabitants, their loyalty to Prime or other factions, Horde's assets, natural resources.

"Shit!" swears Miriann suddenly.

"What is it?" asks Lonnie, yet she has trouble removing her sight from the display.

"Same *galaxy* as always…" Miriann gestures at its representation on the map, intently and dramatically on purpose. She is pretty sure the word isn't used on Etheria yet and it wouldn't do much good to have Lonnie or Catra ask about it in front of these outsiders. "But I never heard of this Horde before. Therefore even if it actually covered only a part of it, I probably never lived in this same period of time, which means all my knowledge is, as usual, useless!!"

“Or maybe it is time to accept that you are completely delusional?” scoffs Catra beside her.

“But I’m not-”

“Oh please, you tried and we called your bluff. I’m sure you can find lots of little kids who will love your stories!”

Bob shrugs and sighs again, not really amused by their crazy bickering. But using this as a distraction, he slowly backs off to the door with his two acolytes. Catra and Lonnie are too late to catch up on it and when they do, Bob tosses something at the console and the three men dash out of the room. Catra jumps forward to the door but it closes violently in front of her. Lonnie runs and grabs Entrapta and Copy-Kyle away from the console, an instant before the device thrown by Bob explodes.

“Move!” Lonnie points her hand cannon at the door and shouts to Catra, who jumps away understandingly.

Lonnie fires and the door shatters in small, smoking pieces. As expected by Catra, she is using the version of these cannons that Entrapta tinkered with. The feline girl and Miriann dash out of the room and they run after the outsiders, who didn’t go far yet since they thought they were safe. But they quickly start to run too. Bob’s astonished expression is priceless, as he suddenly realises that he must take these Etherians seriously, or at least their weapons.

Lonnie stays and takes the time to check that both Entrapta and herself are unharmed, and assesses the situation. The console is ruined and Copy-Kyle seems about to cry from fear when she grabs his collar.

“What is the meaning of this?” demands Lonnie.

“Please don’t hurt meeeeee!!”

“Then talk!” She points her weapon at his head.

“I don’t know! He just needed me to unlock the server! He has other people ready to download what he wants from the main command room!”

“What is he after?”

“I- don’t-” The man trembles and stutters.

“Speak!”

“I don’t know!” He starts to cry and Entrapta rolls her hair around him and pats his head with a strand.

Lonnie doesn’t really get the complicated look that Entrapta is giving her but she at least understands that she shouldn’t insist anymore. She glances at the dead console. “Can you still find anything useful?”

Entrapta grabs her trackpad with her hands, leaving her hair around the thin guy, who starts to panic as he realises that the hair moves. He apparently was so absorbed by his science earlier that he didn’t even notice. Lonnie simply shrugs. He isn’t the first person she knows that is tunnel-focused enough to ignore everything else. Adora, Catra, Hordak, Hunty, even Kyle now that he has something he is interested in.

“Not from here.” answers Entrapta after a few checks. “But he is right, the data flows indicate that informations are being accessed from somewhere else!”

“Lead the way.” orders Lonnie, but Entrapta is already running while dragging Copy-Kyle behind her with her hair, ignoring his protest, surprise and fear all at once.

After a chase through a few corridors, Miriann and Catra are suddenly welcomed in a bigger room by an intense suppressing fire from diverse weapons. They back off and hide on the little

space on each side of the entrance but they can't really do more for now.

"Hey, hum, I know we aren't suppose to talk right now," Silkya's voice suddenly comes from their earpieces. "But there is a big glowy princess-like woman with a sword approaching the ship from outside without a spacesuit?"

"Call her Adora and see if she answers?" suggests Catra, and she smiles because it's both funny and comforting to know that some people aren't completely idolising her girlfriend's godly side, to the point they don't even know that it's Adora.

"That- this- may be Adora?!"

"Wait, you can't-" tries to intervene Entrapta but she is interrupted.

"I made Adora promise not to transform during training." answers Lonnie matter-of-factly. "But I didn't expect anyone of you to *not know*?"

"Oh, we know, Silkya is just weird!" replies Miriann playfully and she chuckles, contrasting for an instant the grim background noises of bullets and beams passing close to her.

"But you can't-"

"I'm not! What's so good about her little sword anyway? It's a butter knife compared to mine!" Silkya tries to justify her lack of goddess' knowledge.

"Oh oh, is it jealousy I hear?" retorts Miriann sweetly.

"You can't call her in space!" yells Entrapta, a little frustrated to be repetitively interrupted.

"Why not?" asks Catra, with frustration in her voice too. Her idea was half a joke but she really doesn't like when someone tells her what she can and can't do.

“There’s no air in space, sounds doesn’t travel through nothing! You need to wait until she is inside the force field!” And for energy efficiency, said force field stays quite close to the hull of the ship. Entrapta explained this much during the briefing earlier, but she didn’t mention anything about sounds, only deathly dangers if one was to go outside unprotected.

“Why does space hate me so much! First the lack of gravity, then the void forcing me to wear boots, now this, why is space so annoying?!” whines Catra suddenly.

“I knew that much.” adds Silkya smugly. “She is waving at me! She is trying to sign something, I think?”

“It’s Adora, don’t expect her to get onboard subtly.” snickers Catra, still frustrated, just before she hears a loud *crash* through her earpiece.

“*That* she didn’t!” Silkya laughs openly, purposefully keeping her microphone active while she does. “Alright, back on the mission with the glowy princess as support then. I’m off.”

Catra turns her attention to the room ahead. She is fast, but this many weapons and the narrow entrance isn’t really in her favour. She glances at the tall woman pressed against the other wall of the hallway.

“Can you do something useful or not?” asks Catra a little more reproachful that she intended, but Miriann does seem to be useless on this mission.

“I *could* use magic but…”

“You said you couldn’t earlier?!”

“Well, I lied, obviously. And that’s not my concern anyway.”

“How worse could it get?”

“I don’t know? Blowing up a hole in the hull I guess? Entrapta, how strong is the field of energy around the ship? Can I make magic explosions without crashing it?”

“I need more data to answer that question!”

“Like what?”

“What kind of explosions? What force and heat are you talking about? Maximum pressure, velocity of the shock wave, temperature, potential secondary explosions, shield’s energy buffer size, distance between the shield generators-”

“Okay, okay, forget it!” Miriann hastily stops the princess and Catra lets out a little sigh of relief. “We’ll just have to hope it holds.”

Catra tenses up because before she can object, the crazy woman has already created a magic sigil in front of her. The feline girl has seen Sparkles and Micah do this a few times but this one seems really more unstable as it vibrates and twinkles. Very loudly, a torrent of fire gushes out of it violently, making the entire place shake, and Catra has to recoil as far as possible against the wall to prevent her fur to be ruined. She does manage to keep it safe, but the fire is so wild and uncontrolled, plus Miriann has a scary smile on her face, that all she can think is ‘at least it didn’t explode’!

Fire and claws

"Oh shit. Duck!"

Without daring taking any time to think about what may be happening, Catra dives to the floor and makes herself as small as possible, laying her tail down along her leg. She might not be that knowledgable about science and stuff, but one thing she knows about fire and explosions, it's that they like to go up. She flattens her ears and covers them with her hands in order to protect them from both heat and violent sounds.

The next instant, she hears a loud *bang* and a burning hot shock wave passes above her. She glances aside to catch Miriann in the same position, but unlike Catra, she is grinning like an idiot, smugly, similarly to how Adora usually does when she succeeds at something pointless but is still proud of herself. However, when Catra loves it from her blonde princess, she has trouble appreciating this from that other woman, even more so in a situation that almost made her fur and hair disappear in a puff of smoke.

"Alright, seems clear." announces Miriann after taking a glance inside the room, once the fire has passed and the silence returned.

They both enter to find the walls and furnitures charred and destroyed. There are still embers and ashes everywhere, but nobody in sight anymore. Suddenly Catra flops down and hide behind the remains of a table. Miriann looks at her, then at the opposite entrance, but they are alone and nothing else moves.

"Did you… we… kill them?" Catra's voice comes out small and unsure.

"*I* didn't." answers Miriann strongly but Catra is still acting weirdly uneasy. "They fired at us first, you know?"

“But-”

“No buts, howbeits, nor asses! Even if yours *is* cute!”

“What the heck?” Catra manages to chuckle at the impromptu silliness.

“You know, *buts*, *butts*, *asses*…” explains Miriann before considering that explaining a pun usually means it failed miserably, and also usually makes the one that made it look like an idiot. “Anyway, they fled at once when my magic went crazy-”

“Isn’t that from the beginning?”

“Yeah, kind of! As expected!” laughs Miriann openly.

“And you still used it without hesitation… I thought you were the sensible type, the one planning and everything!”

“Oh, surely not! Ask Silk for that! I like being well informed, but beyond that, thinking isn’t my thing!” She laughs again. “Come on! We can’t let them get too much ahead of us!” She extends a hand to Catra.

The feline girl grabs it hesitantly and lets herself be pulled up. But as soon as she is standing, she shakes it off violently. Why does she keep letting her guard down like that? She isn’t a soft little creature who needs help all the time! Miriann looks at her, a little offended, and scowls for a second and a half, before smiling again. She steps farther inside and stops behind what’s left of the makeshift barricade from which their opponents were firing at them. Catra takes a deep breath to steel herself and joins Miriann. Judging from the marks on the floor, there probably was a crate full of weapons and ammo here that didn’t do well against fire.

“Oh oh, that’s what exploded! Wasn’t all my fault after all! I *did* managed to keep my spell confined inside this one room.” adds Miriann, way to proud of herself to Catra’s taste, for someone who just learnt after the fact that she succeeded and probably by mere luck.

Catra gasps. She feels mentally exhausted, with her mind getting constantly roller-coastered by her feelings for the place and her weird company this time around. Does she even need to point out that it was totally completely one hundred percent Miriann's fault, regardless of *what* exploded? She probably better not. She really wants to but she feels like arguing with that woman would only wear her out even more, and she sighs heavily.

They start running carefully forward and soon Catra starts to recognise this part of the ship. Then, as they move away from the fire, she picks up the scent of the other party easily. They seem to be headed to the command room. If by chance Lonnie's group is heading there too, and if her sense of direction isn't too disturbed by her emotions, they should approach from different ways, and they might even catch the outsiders between them.

Of course Catra doesn't like to rely on luck and doesn't really count on this chase to work out just like that. Therefore, she isn't even surprised when they are welcomed by heavy fire again as they take the next corner of the corridor. They jump back out of harm's way but something is suddenly intriguing Catra. In contrast from the first time, there are only green beams shot at them, and they seem oddly familiar. She takes another peek at their reception committee. Bots. Horde bots.

"Guys?" Lonnie's voice resonates through their earpieces. "It seems that on purpose or not, they activated a bunch of defence robots while messing with Prime's data. Be careful."

"We kind of noticed!" replies Miriann swiftly.

But Catra barely hears it. There is suddenly an incredible itch crawling under the skin of her fingertips that she can't ignore, and even takes all her attention. She feels a thrill on the back of her neck as if her entire being demands payback for her time chipped. Her claws are out before she realises that she wants them to. She is dashing forward before she can plan her attack, yet her mind is surprisingly clear. She can fight robots! She doesn't have to think

about morals and being better and all that! She lets her instincts free without fear and she aims to destroy without holding back.

The feline girl easily dodges the salve of green energy coming at her, then jumps. The first bot falls on the floor as she drops on it and slices its head in half. She makes another jump to evade shots from the other enemies and lands behind one, which she disposes of in a swift thrust of claws through its torso. She tosses what's left of the robot at yet another one that hits the wall hard enough to get seriously damaged. She moves as a shadow behind her *projectile*, confusing the aim of the rest of her opponents, and slashes both legs of two of them which drop loudly on the ground. She grabs the cannon of the first one to fire at the other, before she crushes its head under her foot.

Catra hasn't moved her body like this since her fight with the tech worm- monster- or whatever was guarding the Heart of Etheria. She didn't stop training because she likes to be strong but she had no real opponent. She said she would come to train with Adora and Lonnie and her recruits in the morning, but she hasn't yet. And she suddenly regrets it very much because they often hold sparring sessions and she feels delightfully good right now. And while a part of it comes from this belated revenge against Prime, another is simply because she loves that kind of exercise.

She stopped because she was afraid to hurt people. But thinking about it more clearly, she had been sparring with her squad of cadets for years without incidents. She did hurt them on occasions but almost all of those actually happened outside of the training room! *Catra strikes another bot down and beheads a second again, one more gets shredded by her claws.* And while it is regrettable on its own, it has nothing to do with her present concern! She regrets having been so held back by an unfounded fear. If she hadn't, she wouldn't have built up so much desire to crush and frustration. She thought she had to withhold and hide it, yet on the contrary it only got worse, and the fear of hurting someone during training only grew.

But unlike a lot of her regrets, this one can be easily corrected, and that too, feels good. Adora already offered Catra to train with them. The princess even asked because she wanted to spend more time with her feline girlfriend, almost begged since Catra was so reluctant.

“Hu… hmm… Cat- Miss Intendant? Is everything alright?”

Catra flinches. She is standing in front of her last *victim*, the last of the bots present in fact, which lays on the floor already too damaged to move, and she has one foot still on its upper body, her claws jabbed in the metal, and she is smirking, as Miriann was before when she set the room on fire. She slowly turns her head to look in the tall woman’s direction. Her arms and clothes are covered by scratches but she is otherwise unharmed. She doesn’t gratify Miriann with a clear answer, silently appreciating the sight of the dozen of bots shattered on the floor.

“Catra?” Lonnie’s voice again.

The feline girl finally leaves her little world of dream and satisfaction. “What?”

“Told you she wasn’t listening.” Miriann tries to keep her voice as neutral as possible since she absolutely doesn’t want to make this wild Catra angry right now.

“I was somewhat busy!” retorts the feline girl but her smile is almost audible.

“Entrapta detected that another ship has docked with the Velvet Glove.” repeats Lonnie.

“Reinforcements?”

“Maybe. The.. *science guy* said no.”

“We can’t trust him!”

"Obviously…" sighs Lonnie. Not that long ago, it would have been a given for both of them not to trust strangers but their constant contact with princesses is slowly turning everything upside down. Of course it would be best if they could trust everyone but that's just not how it works!

Lonnie is running ahead of Entrapta and Copy-Kyle. She managed to make the weird princess understand that it was more safe that way. And while it seems so obvious in her own head, it seems to be a very complicated notion in Entrapta's. They are using a few very narrow corridors and she guesses that it's not supposed to be the main way but more like maintenance shortcuts. And for what she has seen of Entrapta so far, it fits her pretty much, as she did the same in the Fright Zone, still does it inside other ships, and even her own castle.

Lonnie has no idea where she is going, of course, and follows the princess' directions, only stopping here and there to shoot a few bots. Her modified hand cannon is absolutely unfair. She has no idea how Entrapta could improve it that much and she is starting to wonder if it will suddenly explode or something to justify why it wasn't built like this from the beginning.

They arrive in the command room certainly not by the main entrance. The sight of the round platform below makes Entrapta gasp in a mix of fear and fondness. That's where Hordak was ordered to kill her but didn't, and the big display is still shattered in its centre where Prime crashed through it before falling down. The room itself is huge and spherical, and there are a few catwalks following the wall, surrounding the whole thing, and the trio is currently on one of those, the closest to the platform.

Entrapta did good, as always. And as always as well, it feels surprising, and Lonnie can't hide a little smile of admiration. There are three people guarding the main entrance, a narrow staircase to access the command platform, and another four on the platform itself, messing with cables and trackpad-like devices. Bob

is among them. They haven't notice Lonnie's group yet and the three make themselves as discreet as possible. Copy-Kyle seems docile enough for now and from this position they can run away easily if they need to.

"Boss, we've got another ship incoming!" says one of the unknown men.

"Reinforcements?" asks Bob back and Lonnie scoffs silently at the mirroring conversation.

"Maybe. I don't… Wait… I know this ship's energy signature! It's the Blue Hawk!"

"What the hell is *she* doing here?!" Bob seems suddenly very agitated at the mention of that name.

"No way she would ignore a juicy contract like this one."

"But we were the only one who knew where to look!"

Beside Lonnie, Copy-Kyle giggles quietly. "What is it?" she whispers.

"She probably put a tracker on him, again."

"Who is *she*?"

"The captain of the Blue Hawk. One of the boss… acquaintances? He thinks he is so good and attractive that any woman with half a brain takes advantage of him. He won't admit it, but I think he kind of feels it and that's why there are only men on his crew!"

Like with science, this thin, reserved, almost ghostly guy becomes all talkative when something gets his interest, and apparently his boss' affairs with women seems funny enough to him.

"Did you get it?" Bob's now impatient and uneasy voice resonates again.

“Almost.” The other man nervously types commands on his tool again, before brightening a moment later. “Got it! Here!” He unplugs a small device and holds it to Bob, who grabs it hastily and puts it in his pocket.

“Let’s go before she or the *Etherians* show up!” shouts Bob to his team.

Bots of love

“Catra, how far are you from the command room?” asks Lonnie in a whisper.

“Almost there? How did you-”

“Bob and the two others are here already. I won’t believe you can’t track them?”

Catra grunts a little. It feels like a loss now that she understands that Lonnie beat her to catch up to them. She did get distracted on her way here but the feeling just doesn’t seem to take that into consideration.

“He’s about to leave!” urges Lonnie.

“Capt’n! There are active bots in the main hangar!” interrupts Silkya’s voice.

“You are a little behind on the informations here!” snickers Catra. She feels like it’s not the first time the other girl isn’t following and she won’t miss a chance to tell her.

“No. I mean a hell of a lot of robots! There are heavy assault ones too! Like, hundreds of them!”

“That’s right!” Entrapta joins the conversation after checking on her trackpad. “The bulk of the ship’s defence garrison activated when something punched a hole in the hull.”

“Aaaadooooooraaaaaa!!” shouts Catra frustrated.

“She can’t hear you…”

“Oh sure she can when you yell like that! Please mind our ears, *kitty*!” There is a little pause and a few clangs and energy beams’ sounds echo through the earpieces. “We… may need a little help!” adds Silkya.

“Alright, change of plan. Miriann, Catra, go help them, I’ll deal with Bob.”

“Entrapta? Map please?” Miriann gets a trackpad out of her small backpack and it beeps an instant later. “Thanks. This way!” She starts running and Catra follows her swiftly, not even wanting to think about why the tall woman has one of those nor why she didn’t use it before.

“Hurry please!” insists Silkya as the impacts and crashes in her audio background grow louder.

“Please stay safe, I don’t wanna die yet!” replies Miriann worriedly.

“Don’t you mean you don’t want her to die?!” inquires Catra agitatedly, noting that Silkya isn’t even commenting on this weird retort.

“Well, yeah, that too!”

“What the fuck, *that too*?!” growls Catra. Those two certainly don’t give off all altruistic *princess´* vibes, but they do seem pretty close.

“We are kind of linked together? If she dies, I die!”

“Just move your ass you fatty!” exclaims Silkya’s voice again and they rush faster, while Catra does her best to think that those words weren’t meant for her but Miriann only. However, she can’t be too sure with that blunt little woman.

“Lonnie? You knew about this before taking them on a squad?” asks Catra as she runs, when she realises the unreasonable risk of having those two together in a dangerous mission.

“What? You suddenly believe their nonsense? I didn’t when I recruited them.”

“What about now?”

“Shut up and run!”

Using the nearest arched support pillar as a bridge, Lonnie dashes down to the main platform of the command room. Catching the three men who were packing away their equipments off guard, she drops two of them unconscious before they can even notice her, and she engages the third. One of the advantage of this heavy hand cannon is that it makes for an effective blunt weapon as well, even if Entrapta’s increasing wince, each time she hits something with it, worries her considerably. Thankfully, she doesn’t need many strikes to knock him out too since her expertise in close combat is far above his own, very apparently so.

The four other outsiders are already engaged in the narrow staircase leading out of the room, and as soon as they understand what’s happening, they dash away, and considering that Lonnie is aiming at them already, it probably is the safest course of action for them.

“You think you can deactivate the bots from here? And find out what he took? In that order?” she asks Entrapta who gives her an as-always-when-science-is-involved enthusiastic ‘yes’ in response. She swiftly ties the three unconscious men with the cables they were using and turns to face Copy-Kyle, but before she can move further, Entrapta rolls her hair around him again and forces him to sit beside her. Lonnie sighs and throws her a strong “Be careful.” before starting to run after the others.

Catra and Miriann arrive at the hangar by a side door, the *huge* hangar reflecting Prime’s oversized ideas, that looks more like a giant stockpile of military assets than anything else at the moment. For someone idolising *order* so much, he certainly didn’t look too closely at his own place before judging others’, favouring quantity over organisation.

Or maybe, without his mind to command the whole lot, they lack the coordination to appear all orderly. Nonetheless, the quantity

makes up easily for the clumsy martial impression because Silkya wasn't really exaggerating when she said *hundreds of them*. She and Adora have positioned themselves between a near wall and a high pile of crates, to limit the enemy's angles open to reach them, and they are fighting back to back to cover both remaining sides. Those bots aren't very agile, therefore they don't have to be that mindful of the blind spot above them, but in the back of the room, a few heavy mechs are getting ready to do some serious damage, with cannons big enough to worry even She-Ra. If this army was properly directed, they would have fired already, but now they have trouble advancing and finding a clear line in the middle of this big mess.

The two girls already have each a pretty big *body* count and Catra takes two seconds and a half to appreciate the sight. Her princess has better range with her magic, and *rainbowy* attacks are slicing through air and bots alike, while Silkya wields her imposing sword as if it weighs nothing, using both hands for precision and control rather than strength. Contrary to Adora though, she is quite more graceful, as she *dances* in the middle of a metal rain made of the bots' fragments she is cutting expertly. And while She-Ra's magic is also protecting the princess to a certain extend against some of the beams, the small girl uses the large flat side of her weapon as a shield when she can't dodge. Clearly, if not for the endless number of opponents, and the big ones behind, they wouldn't need any help.

Catra frowns. There is something unbalanced about the way Adora is fighting, and she can't manage to pinpoint what. Until she notices that her sword is definitely bigger than usual and the princess isn't used to it yet, and the feline girl bursts out in stifled laughter. It seems that she was right, the size of Silkya's sword was enough to make her dumb princess jealous.

In a discreet display of acrobatics, she reaches a small passageway above her and follows it in the fight's direction, then jumps from a pile of crates to another, balances herself on a set of beams supporting the roof to reach another crates' stack, until she can drop behind her princess unseen.

“Hey Adora!” says Catra, as close to the princess’ ear as she dares, taking into account She-Ra’s incoming violent reaction at being surprised like this.

As expected Adora jumps and sharply turns around, while her last magic attack misses completely. She freezes when she ears the familiar voice laughing at her, and Catra bridges the gap between them and tries to plant a little kiss on her cheek. Since She-Ra is so tall, Catra has to stand on tiptoe and the princess has enough time to stop her.

“Hey, I’m a little busy right now?”

“Yeah, yeah, whose fault is that?” Catra evades an energy beam, grabbing and dragging Adora down in her arms. Of course, as soon as she gets a hold of herself, She-Ra is physically stronger and stops Catra from leading the dance, pushing her out of another shot’s way to pin her against the wall. And while the feline girl likes to be in charge, being pressed against a wall by her princess is always a sweet experience too.

“Catra, it’s not the right time for this.” Despite her words and her usual mostly impassible attitude, a faint smile adorns She-Ra’s face and she has a hard time leaning back away from her girlfriend, but yet she still does.

“I’m a little annoyed that you’d rather play with your new *toys* than letting me kiss you?”

Adora instantly makes an expression that Catra knows well but hates over everything else. The *I-have-to-do-this* kind of face, that the princess is sadly used to make, mixed with the intense regret of letting go of Catra, who would be happy about the latter part if Adora wasn’t showing so obviously that she is not going to allow herself even this much, nor is she at least doing what she needs to with a smile. It’s quite contradictory to want Adora to either *don’t mind her and work happily* or *mind her enough to stop working*, but the feline girl feels like she has only the bad side of both, and it’s unfair, and it shows on her face too, and it

annoys her even more when Adora starts to make excuses. "I can't let Silkya-"

"**Just kiss her already you inept girl!!**" yells Silkya. She dashes past them, taking down a pair of bots that were approaching a little too close on *Adora's* side, then rushes back to her own side, strongly pushing She-Ra's back in passing.

The shove makes Adora press against Catra again and even as She-Ra, Adora is blushing and she is hesitating as her stupid resolve is shaken. She hurt her girlfriend's feelings, she knows it, but what she still doesn't know is how to act now. She looks aside to see bots coming, and her mind is searching for a way out, a hole to hide from those unfair situations that she still can't seem to do right on her own yet, even after working with Perfuma so much.

She then sees Miriann jumping down from the pile of crates behind her, very much less elegantly than Catra did previously, and following Catra's path took her a lot more time. The tall woman swiftly gets an extensible combat staff out and starts fighting the bots coming from *previously* Adora's side.

The princess' attitude finally cracks, after another back-and-forth run from Silkya to give a hand to Miriann for a few seconds. She lets go of She-Ra and takes Catra in her arms and kisses her on the lips. The feline girl stiffens slightly at first, before relaxing and eagerly returning the kiss, and Adora realises that all that Catra asked for was a little kiss. She didn't even have to be the one giving. Had she simply accepted a kiss on her cheek with a *smile*, she wouldn't have hurt Catra like this. She ponders about the *smile* part some more, because that's the important part, isn't it? Getting better, being happy herself to make Catra happy in turn.

And kissing Catra makes her undeniably happy. Another small thing that she missed, but she won't next time. 'I'll get better, I can do this, I *am* getting better.' She repeats in her head an adapted routine from Perfuma, which works wonderfully... with the help of Catra's warmth as the feline girl is now embracing

Adora strongly within her arms. For a short time, that has the merit of feeling way longer than it really lasts, Adora and Catra are alone in a little bubble just for them, where the sounds of the fight is dimmed and ignored, and they feel only warm.

"Okay, our turn!" announces Silkya loudly as her sword flies behind the two kissing girls, having thrown it to Miriann's side to take down a bot giving trouble to the less fight-efficient tall woman. To her credit, she does well with a simple staff against so many opponents, and her big muscles are real and not only for show, but the literal army coming at them is just too much for her.

The heavy weapon passing loudly behind them, Adora and Catra flinch and part, and their minds come back to the present time and place. Silkya rushes once more and grabs Adora's shoulders, and shoves her to take Miriann's place. She then turns to the feline girl and smirks, and pushes her a little more politely to the side she was defending an instant before.

Protected on four sides by two fighters, a wall and a stack of crates, as Adora and Catra were a moment before, Silkya and Miriann share a brief but sweet kiss in turn. When they part, the short woman sighs and mumbles about having to do everything here, and then dashes to Adora with Miriann in tow. She takes back her sword, still jabbed through the bot it had pierced mid flight, and she points at Catra after getting Adora's attention. The princess doesn't need more explanation, and can't help but grin like an idiot as she rushes to Catra's side.

"That's a good face!" shouts Silkya playfully and Catra has to agree when she glances back to see her blonde girlfriend running to her, even if she is annoyed at someone else pointing it out aloud. But Silkya helped and Catra got her kiss and even more than she actually allowed herself to hope for in this situation, so it doesn't really feel bad. "Don't tell Lonnie!" adds Silkya as she winks at her.

And Catra chuckles. She and Adora may be allowed to do mostly whatever they want here, however the others are still under

Lonnie’s command, and while this army isn’t the Horde, they probably aren’t supposed to goof around nor kiss on the job.

Deception

With the reinforcements, the Etherians begin to be a little more optimistic about the situation. Not that it prevented them to take some time for themselves earlier though, but now they don't have to just hold on their position until Entrapta does her thing. While they feel pretty safe here, they don't have a lot of informations about the outsiders, and getting caught between them and the bots could be a problem.

"What now?" shouts Catra to the other pair, that should be more informed about the present mission than herself. She was only supposed to observe and grade the squad and honestly didn't listen to all the *boring* details that Lonnie gave the other members during the briefing. In addition, it's a good opportunity to see if they are truly capable.

"We are looking for the other guys' ship. But this place is a maze. I understand that connected to Prime's mind, the clones and bots didn't really need for the place to be logically arranged, but it's a pain in the ass!!" Silkya starts to explain as expressive as always. "If Entrapta's data is correct, it should be on the other side of this hangar." Between two strikes, she points her sword at another wall, not the farthest at least, but there are still quite a *few* bots in the way. And thinking about bots, something is bugging Catra now. The big heavy mechs she spotted earlier still haven't made a move, nor fired, and she can't seem to locate them anymore.

Two other groups arrive in the hangar at the same time. The first is Bob's team, or what's left of it, that comes from the same direction as Catra and Miriann did earlier, and the second is new. It's led by a woman and… Catra almost laughs. Just as she noticed in her first meeting with Bob's group, this one too is neither especially showy nor noticeable. It's composed of all kind of people, but all ten of them are human, with various weapons and clothes mostly brown and black. Even the leader stands out only because she is shouting orders while physically *leading* the

charge; she shows a strong commanding attitude but that's about it.

And again it's not really weird, on the contrary after a little reflection it seems very much more logical to not wander about with flamboyant colours or excessive ornaments, but Catra can't help but feel that showy princesses and even the Horde have completely tainted her *normal* vision of the world. The Horde too, because they had very distinct uniforms, and that's without thinking about the white one she was forced to wear for some time. She shivers. This one ended up in Darla's incinerator, and that's for the best...

She had to ask Adora what happened to it. She had to. Because for a time she was afraid to find it every time she was opening a closet or reaching for her other clothes in the morning. She felt stupid. She had braved so many things, done so much harm herself, and here she was troubled by some fricking pieces of fabric! That's one of the moments that helped her realise to what extend she was broken. With that kind of events, she could only either stick very close to Adora, or leave her. And she kinda tried both, and she still can't believe how the latter backfired on her, very positively so.

The two new parties begin to dig their way inside the hangar through the mass of bots. Apparently, Bob really needs to pass by here to reach his ship. But when his men step forward, as he lets them do the slashing, Catra realises that he is holding Lonnie hostage. Which is pretty weird considering she hasn't even tried to communicate since she left Entrapta to go after him.

Adora follows Catra's eyes and instantly takes charge, shouts orders, and starts advancing in the same direction. Silkya simply sighs, shrugs, and rushes to the princess' side and resumes her bots-cutting handiwork. Miriann and Catra stare for an instant, appreciating the sight, and exchange a knowing glance of approval. Their two girlfriends in action is something to behold. They then compose themselves and focus because moving means

they are leaving the cover of the crates and they can't afford to miss a beam.

As the three teams converge together, there are two more things bothering Catra. While those outsiders don't seem to have an extensive military training, they know how to use their weapons well enough, and unlike the slow Horde's energy beams, most of their projectiles are too fast to be seen, which means she probably can't dodge them without very good anticipation. And she really doesn't want to find out if they can hurt She-Ra.

The team led by the new woman doesn't try to go too far too fast and keeps the access to the door behind them secured. They have the advantage of number and have a few heavy anti-robots weapons working very well, and with a bit of luck, they aren't completely on Bob's side. At this pace though, the Etherian team and Bob's will reach them approximately at the same time, therefore Catra will have to manage this smartly, unless She-Ra intends to fight the entire room.

"Hey Boby! You recruit kids now?" shouts the woman leader as they approach, pointing at Catra and Silkya. But while the feline girl recognises that she is probably the youngest of all the people present, the gap between her furious reaction and Silkya's laughter annoys her quite effectively.

"They aren't with me!" Bob frets.

Catra takes a deep breath. Diplomatic. Calm. Relax. Bright Moon's representative and all that. She manages to quickly convince Adora to be on fight-duty while she does the talking herself. To be fair it's not really a challenge for once because they really need Silkya and She-Ra who can protect others while they now stand in the open. The other people are trying to take cover behind crates and what they have on hand but unlike the Etherians' previous well defensible position, there isn't much here.

"Hi, I'm Catra, we come from Etheria, the planet down there. Who are you and what's your angle? We don't intend to fight you, but

Bob has one of our teammate.” she asks the newcomer.

“I do, so don’t make any stupid move!” answers Bob first, hiding behind Lonnie while he tries to keep as much distance with the other Etherians as possible, but the other team doesn’t let him simply pass through either. Lonnie is staying awfully quiet, but she seems to have been ordered to, and for whatever reason that Catra has no time to think about right now, she is obeying.

The leader of the third team suddenly takes two steps in Catra’s direction, who recoils and readies herself to counterattack if needed, but she stops in front of the feline girl with a curious and astonished expression and leans down unguarded towards her to look more closely. “What the… hell? What *are* you? Is this a prosthetic skin or something?”

Catra sighs. Right. She forgot about that. “No. I’m one hundred percent natural, thank you very much! There are a lot of different kinds of people on Etheria. Please step out of whatever hole you are coming from a little more often?”

“Hey, kitty, don’t show your fangs like this. I’ve visited at least a hundred planets and it’s the first time I see someone like you.”

Catra breathes again. Diplomatic. Calm. Relax. “Call me *kitty* again, and you’ll feel my claws too. And just so you don’t pass out in a moment, we also have magic.” She points a claw at She-Ra. At least with her here, it should be easier to make those ignorant people accept the fact that magic exists.

The woman finally leans back and answers after a few more seconds of staring at Catra. “I’m Elena, captain of the Blue Hawk.” She then takes her eyes to She-Ra and seems to ponder again. “Every tech advanced enough seems like magic to people who don’t know how they work.” she recites as if she is used to have people trying to make her believe the unbelievable.

Catra shrugs and breathes once more. Diplomatic. Calm. Relax. The definition of magic doesn’t matter for now. If these people

want to believe that someone would use science to make a sword that shoots rainbows on purpose, so be it. Since the woman didn't answer Catra tries another approach. "Bob, what do you want?"

"Leaving with my team, alive? Let us go and I'll let the girl free as soon as we get to our ship." he answers flatly.

"That's out of the question!" shouts Adora as she turns around.

"Adora, let me deal with this." retorts Catra with a false calm only to not worsen the situation. The princess reluctantly nods, at least agreeing to not start an argument now in front of these strangers, and faces the bots again

There are not that many coming too close anymore as they seem to have finally acknowledged the danger of this larger group. Catra winces again as she notices, because there is still no sign of the big assault mechs, and having them wreak havoc at this fragile position from afar would be the logical next step, military wise.

"Who's going to pay more?" Elena smiles, smelling the opportunity of a nice profit without even having to work. "I know the price of the contract, Boby. Eighty-twenty and you can pass. With or without the girl, I don't care." She doesn't wait for the man to answer and turns to Catra. "What can *you* offer, kitty?"

Diplomatic. Calm. Relax. 'Fuck it'. Without warning and very swiftly, Catra punches her violently in the face.

Elena staggers back and puts a more appropriately safe distance between the feline girl and herself, with a very troubled expression showing that she absolutely didn't anticipate this. Catra didn't expect the attack to connect so easily either, but apparently Elena was more shocked by the discovery of *her being not human* than she let out, and had her guard completely off.

"Catra!!" Adora spins around again and dashes to the feline girl's side.

“What? Why does everyone think they can just call me whatever they want?! I warned her! Silkya, it counts for you too!”

“Yes ma’am! Duly noted!”

“Please don’t be violent with people before we know they are bad!” pleads Adora hastily without really thinking about how her sentence can be very weirdly interpreted.

“What about disrespecting me? Isn’t that bad enough for you?” As usual, trying to make Adora side with her isn’t easy for Catra.

“Keep your pet on a leash!” exclaims Elena as she regains her senses.

Adora stiffens. And slowly, but adamantly, she turns in the newcomer’s direction. With her very serious face, She-Ra advances and before Elena knows it, she is face to face with the princess. But as She-Ra, Adora is tall, big, imposing, commanding, and at this distance, every part of Elena that thought she looked ridiculous in this outfit have retreated far in the back of her mind.

“Call her a pet again and *I’ll* punch you too. I won’t be as gentle as her.” She-Ra’s voice is calm as always, but her eyes are burning in blue magical fires and her big, clenched fist is glowing.

The other woman gulps audibly and takes a step back. Thankfully for her, Adora is called by Silkya to come and take her defensive position once more. The blonde girl hesitates, wondering briefly if the small woman did it just to defuse the situation, when suddenly the room becomes completely silent.

Understanding that without the bots issue, the situation may become a lot more complicated, Elena and her troops start to retreat to the door from which they came by, while now pointing their weapons at everyone else. “Boby, do we have a deal?”

“Yes, yes, we’ll settle the details later!” Bob’s answer is curt and instant, and he is starting to sweat at the otherwise prospect of having to fight these crazy Etherians with only three men, now

that the robots aren't a distraction anymore. From afar he would have more room for manoeuvre, but they are too close for comfort and a hostage can only get him so far.

"I'm sorry, it seems the negotiation just ended." adds Elena and her team's weapons redirect to point only at the Etherians. The room gets silent again in a sort of stand-off, since the Etherians didn't really agree to the situation, while Bob is very slowly making Lonnie walk sideways as he stays behind her to use her as a shield.

Adora is ready to rush head on, only delayed by having to take Lonnie's safety into consideration for a moment. Catra knows that her princess is thinking too much about it, and also thinking she is the one who has to do everything dangerous, like she would gladly trade places with Lonnie if she could, and the feline girl hates it as always. It's even the princess' fault that things got so crazy this time. She is about to start arguing when someone unexpectedly laughs, breaking the silence.

"And here I thought I could learn something useful…" sighs Lonnie.

The next instant, one of Bob's minions shakes violently as if he has been electrocuted and drops on the ground, while Lonnie grabs Bob's shoulder and literally throws him over her head, her wrists tied up together not doing much to stop her. He lands loudly on his back a few feet away while another of his men falls on the floor in the same manner as the first, and the third finds himself with Miriann's staff against his head, very explicitly ready to strike if he dares move.

"I hope we can learn more from you. *This* seems valuable." says Lonnie to Elena playfully, as she tosses and catches a few times the little storage device that Bob pocketed earlier in the command room.

Bluff and bullets

"First thing first. You don't know that the Horde has been defeated either I presume?" inquires Lonnie.

"Bullshit, that's impossible!" Elena's reaction is so close to Bob's earlier that Lonnie has to smile. It won't help the discussion if she looks like she is mocking the other woman but it's just too much and fun. For their lack of visual individuality, those two certainly seem to have quite the pair of characters.

"We are here in his flagship, and Bob can confirm that we shot Prime's main body. We destroyed his mind too, but on the planet's surface so I can't give you proof of that for now." Lonnie summarises the situation quickly.

Still on the floor, Bob grunts and shamefully stands back up again. He keeps his hands open and somewhat up to show that he doesn't want to fight, before facing Elena and nodding to confirm Lonnie's claim. His eyes then dart back and forth between the two women, as he isn't sure if he should walk to either side, or run away, but certainly not stay in the middle like an idiot between two armies ready to charge or open fire.

"Therefore, you coming here, considering the potential danger, only makes sense if *this* is truly priceless." resumes Lonnie, showing the little device that she stole again, since Elena doesn't move nor retort.

Since he is ignored, Bob carefully takes a few steps out of the way and Elena gestures to her people to let him come closer, after what she sighs heavily at his clumsiness and looks back at Lonnie to answer. "Everything has a price, princess."

But completely disregarding the cynicism in her voice, most of the Etherians begin to laugh. It starts muffled, as they try not to be too rude and interrupt Lonnie's conversation, but it grows quickly and Lonnie herself is chortling soon too.

"*Princess*, she said!" Silkya is the first to really burst out wholeheartedly laughing of course, but Catra follows shortly after, fully on the same wavelength as her for once.

Because unknown to this bunch of outsiders, Etheria has quite the history with princesses. And of all the Etherian women present, Lonnie is one of the two who has nothing to do with being a princess. Entrapta is one, obviously. Adora is arguably the Princess of princesses with She-Ra's powers, Miriann dreamt to be one, and Silkya has the typical looks, with her slender and graceful figure, her long flowing platinum blonde hair and her noble attitude. As long as her mouth stays shut, the other may argue. But neither Catra nor Lonnie ever thought of being princesses, even in their wildest *what ifs*.

"Should we get Entrapta? Letting her do the negotiation could be fun!" jokes Miriann, somewhat tastelessly and she gets slapped on the back of the head by Silkya.

While Catra and Lonnie would have considered being called *princess* an insult not so long ago, and while Elena very obviously didn't mean it as a compliment, after the emotions of the chase and fight earlier, that's all it took to make the whole group laugh.

"I'm sorry, if you want a princess, talk to that one!" scoffs Lonnie as she points at She-Ra.

However, to an outsider's point of view, She-Ra looks *princessy* only when she is focused and serious, commanding and inflexible. And while she doesn't show her hilarity as much as the others, she still arguably seems like a *giant clumsy idiot*, as Catra would put it, when Adora's snorty laugh suddenly outweighs She-Ra's elegant one. Elena looks at the princess questioningly and her cool expression drops more and more as the conversation completely escapes her grasp.

"Told you they were clowns…" mumbles Bob as he walks behind Elena without being stopped since her team completely forgot about him when the Etherians started laughing.

“Shut up, Boby. If you hadn’t let yourself be robbed by this teenager-”

“Wouldn’t have been so much in a hurry if *you* hadn’t shown up!”

Miriann interrupts them suddenly when she hears the female captain calling him like that again. “Wait wait wait, your name really is *Bob*?” She was certain he was mocking them when he gave that short simple name, and without any kind of title, rank or origin.

“His name’s Robert, but he hates it! *Boby* suits him better anyway, it’s cute and soft! He makes his men call him *boss* anyway… since *captain Bob* sounds dumb as hell!” Elena smirks and Bob starts to mumble snarky insults about her big mouth.

“Lets get back to business!” resumes Lonnie impatiently when she manages to get her serious back again. She can’t say that she wasn’t curious about the name herself but not to the point of actually asking, and they still haven’t learnt anything really useful. “We have whatever you came here for, we have an army of robots that one of our people can activate again and make shoot only at you, we have magic, and we saved the universe not long ago. What do *you* have to offer? I’m sure you have some informations that we could use, at least. Who are you really, and how come you weren’t aware of Prime’s defeat, for example. I’m sure you have some ideas?”

“It feels like you don’t know much about the outside world either, right?” asks Bob back.

“That’s correct. Which makes any information you have valuable, otherwise you wouldn’t have anything we might want.” admits Lonnie honestly. She is already bluffing boldly with claiming that the bots are under their control and she knows she shouldn’t push it.

There is a sharp and loud *bang*, instantly followed by a metallic *clang* as Silkya jumps in front of Lonnie, covered by her sword

which vibrates from the impact.

“Hey, rude much?” retorts Silkya curtly. Elena’s handgun is pointed at them and if not for the obvious target of Lonnie’s arm holding Bob’s storage device, the shot wouldn’t have been so easily intercepted. Silkya winces and whispers to Lonnie. “This one was telegraphed, don’t expect me to stop random bullets for you!”

“I’ve got lead. Is that *valuable* enough for you?” replies Elena angrily.

But only silence follows, and Lonnie’s questioning face makes Silkya sigh again. “Lead. Bullets! Her weapon’s projectiles! She is making fun of you!!” explains Silkya swiftly, torn between laughter and despair since she feels like she has to teach very basic stuff yet she was the one being called *out of touch* with common things earlier.

She-Ra takes a step forward because unless it comes from Catra, she really hates being mocked, and as another *bang* echoes in the hangar, her shoulder is hit and thrown back violently. After an instant of silence as every breath is held through the entire room, she straightens herself slowly. She doesn’t really show any wound nor pain, but Catra is too good at reading her and she just knows that her princess is very much hurting like crazy. Nonetheless, Adora is ready to rush in and Catra doesn’t know what she hates the most; that someone hurt Adora, or that Adora still doesn’t seem to care about herself.

But *what the feline girl knows* is that when she is She-Ra, her princess’ faults are enhanced just as much as her physical strength. Catra is strong too though, and she grabs and tosses Adora down behind a line of crates to prevent her to do anything crazy and take cover. The other Etherians do the same and dives next to them when a few more shots are fired in their direction, yet unlike the bots or Bob’s team, Elena and her people seem to want to spare their so-called *bullets* and do not shower them with intense fire.

Adora grunts unhappily but it seems to be more from the fact that she has been almost thrown to the ground by Catra than her shoulder's pain, which does a lot to reassure the feline girl who kisses Adora's forehead before the princess can stand up again. She-Ra slightly blushes and freezes, still on the floor, long enough for Catra to evaluate the situation and turns to face Lonnie.

"Where's your hand cannon?" asks the feline girl while she keeps her grip on Adora and doesn't let her move.

"I had to lose it to be believably taken hostage."

"And the bots?"

"Technically, Entrapta can probably do it, since she managed to stop them, but I haven't briefed her on that so…" answers Lonnie matter-of-factly and Catra starts to argue that she may have tried to bluff her way out a little too much there.

"Entrapta? Can you have the bots help us against the other guys?" asks Silkya impatiently before her two commanding officers are finished talking.

"You want me to have these cuties blow up everything else?"

"Okay, sounds very bad when you put it that way! Forget it!"

"Should I try some magic?" asks Miriann hesitantly.

"No. I've got better. Hey, Elena, want to see some magic?" Lonnie shouts the second half for the other teams to hear.

"No thanks!" retorts Elena. "Throw me the device and we'll leave you in peace."

"Catra, let me go!" whispers Adora strongly as the feline girl is still mostly on top of her to keep her down.

"No. How many of those *bullets* do you think you can take?!" answers Catra just as strongly. She-Ra should be able to easily

shove her aside but the feline girl takes advantage of the fact that these days Adora is very wary of any action that feels like pushing her away, even in this situation it seems, thankfully.

“What do we do with him?” interrupts Miriann as she points a finger at the third of Bob’s men who she was threatening earlier, and who *not knowing what to do* has taken cover with them instead of running to the other side.

“Please don’t mind me! I’m just waiting here for this to be over! When these two are together it never ends well for us anyway!” he hurriedly answers, trying to make himself as small as possible.

Lonnie looks at him for a few seconds, then glances at the other team over the crates. It just doesn’t seem like they care at all and so she decides against trying to use him as a hostage or shield for now. It would probably only look like an act of desperation and she still has some *magic* to scare them with. She holds one hand up, high enough above the crates to be visible by the other team. “One!” she shouts as she lifts a finger, and an instant later one of Elena’s people takes the same kind of shock as Bob’s men earlier and falls on the floor. “Two!” Another finger and another body drops. Before she can say *three*, Bob, Elena and her team take shelter behind other crates and boxes too.

“What the heck was that?!” exclaims Catra but Lonnie only winks, harbouring a wide grin because it’s not often that she can get back at her with surprises like this.

“I’m still waiting for interesting informations in exchange for the storage device!” says Lonnie to try and make Bob and Elena talk again.

“You can’t!!” Entrapta’s voice explodes through their earpieces, making the whole team flinches as they didn’t anticipate the high pitch and volume. “You absolutely can’t give them back what they took!”

“Finally.” Lonnie sighs, from relief for once, at the sign of Entrapta having some clue of what the other groups are after. “What is it?”

“It’s the chips!”

“What do you mean?” Catra is the first to react since the simple mention of it makes her fur stand on end.

“Everything! The schematic, how to make them, how to control people with them!”

“Didn’t you destroy them already?”

“I only set up a short range transmission of interferences that deactivate the chips temporarily, long enough for the chips to detach from the host! If this data gets out, Etheria might be the only safe place in the universe, until we go and set up similar emitters in other places! And the clones scattered out there are likely to become tools again…”

“Hey, isn’t she unusually perceptive and touchy?” tosses Silkya hesitantly at the others.

“Her… hmm… lab partner has been chipped for quite a while.” answers Lonnie simply. She would rather not be too specific about clones right now, since the only information they got from Bob is that this is a delicate topic. “As socially awkward as she may be, it’s not something she can take lightly.”

Most leave, one stays

“Entrapta, is it safe to destroy this storage thingy?” asks Catra.

“Yes?” answers the princess quizzically as if she expects a hidden meaning behind the question, yet it is only an honest worry for not-science-savvy people. You never know with advanced tech, it might explode, or turn She-Ra crazy, or almost destroy the universe.

“Alright. Lock everything up, make sure nobody can access it again. And Silkya, take care of this.” orders Lonnie as she tosses her the device, but Catra intercepts it.

“I’ll do it…” announces the feline girl lowly.

She is trembling just knowing what is stored in there but she wants to destroy it all the more herself. She starts to hesitantly poke at it with a claw, then strokes, strikes, and slashes, and cuts and crushes, and quickly enough there's nothing left but dust and she is breathing heavily. Adora puts a hand on her shoulder and Catra puts her own over it to convey that she appreciates the gesture. Nobody says a word for a few moments.

“Did you just do what I think you did?!” Bob’s voice resonates once more through the otherwise silent room.

“Whatever you came here for is gone. You should leave now. Before we decide that we should blow up this whole place.” Lonnie’s words are poised and solemn… She didn’t know she could speak this way. Usually there is more passion in her voice, but She-Ra is the one who looks unusually expressive, ready to explode, only kept in place by Catra still sitting mostly on her laps. There are just things that shouldn’t be, even in the middle of a war, and the chips’ existence is one of them.

“You really have no idea how much money we could have earn with this!!”

“Have you ever been or had a friend be chipped?” retorts Lonnie.

“No-”

“Then you better shut up. That’s not something you want out there. Believe us, we are unfortunately very aware of it.”

The other side starts to whisper, in the same way it happened at the very beginning, and Lonnie starts breathing again. Her heart is racing faster than when she is fighting. She hasn’t been nervous like this in a long time. Maybe since her first encounter with Octavia when she was young? She has dealt well with cadets, with Force Captains, she bore with annoying people like Catra, *genius* like Adora, recently managed to converse with princesses somewhat more easily than she expected, but this kind of diplomacy is new, and intense, in a way she never experienced before. Every words feel heavy, every decisions seem to support the weight of the world.

“What now then? What about my men?” inquires Bob.

“If you agree to leave, they are free to go. On the other hand, if you want to start all this over, you can come with us on Etheria and discuss everything more calmly with our leaders. Unarmed, of course. I told you, we didn’t come here to fight.”

“Yeah, right!” scoffs Elena.

“Alright, I’ll come.” announces Bob, taking everyone off guard.

“What?!” shouts the captain at his side loudly. “That doesn’t make sense! *They* don’t make sense!”

“I agree.” retorts Bob without hesitation. “And you know how much I hate that! Nothing here makes sense! Prime’s absence, their presence, their *planet’s presence* for that matter, their magic, or advanced tech if you prefer to call it that, the cat-girl, the fact they could access the ship’s computer in a few minutes when we couldn’t in a week!”

“You have been here a week?!” exclaims Silkya.

“What’s a week?” whispers Lonnie and the short woman facepalms.

“Five or seven days…” chortles Miriann.

“I really hate the universe’s randomness!” erupts Silkya. “Why are those usually constant in human worlds and why do they not apply here?! Wait, is Etheria not *human* enough to have those, or too magic? That would kinda make sense… What about years? No, those might be mostly necessary for a planet to sustain life, the word itself may not matter, only its astronomical meaning...” she continues to mumble to herself lower and lower.

“It didn’t occur to you that they even might be from the Horde themselves?” argues Elena.

“Them?! With those appearances, with this glowy warrior? That’s even more stupid than thinking they are Empire spies!” answers Bob.

“Oh, so there is an empire out there?” interrupts Lonnie, interested to have finally heard *something* that sounds like a new information about the outside world.

“Don’t expect much from it…” replies Bob flatly.

“Why? They are not any better than the Horde?”

“Let us all leave, and I’ll come back in ten days. Then we can talk. I need to take care of a few things first.”

“Like writing your will?” retorts Elena.

“Let me guess,” interrupts Silkya again before the two captains' argument becomes lover-quarrel-style bickering. “Half this part of the galaxy was controlled by the Horde, the other was enslaved by this so-called *empire* in order to have enough resources to fight the first. And since Bob is unexpectedly more touched by

that last part than you, although you two get along well, you tend to argue and compete instead of working together-”

“Whatever fits your dream… I’m out of here.” Elena sighs strongly enough to be heard by the Etherians. She swiftly gives short orders and some of her teammates grab the two unconscious ones to carry them out.

“Entrapta, make sure they go straight back to their ships!” announces Lonnie loudly to be certain that the other captains heard. “Then we’ll discuss how to protect this place so it’s not visited again without our consent.”

“Hey, if you make it dangerous, you better set up proper warning protocols! You don’t want *good and honest* scavenger getting killed by some bots or traps.” adds Elena with a very purposefully annoyingly entitled tone of voice.

But since it does seem fair and probably better for future relationships, Lonnie relays the idea to Entrapta, who seems a little confused about how to do such a thing when another voice answers in her place. “I’ll show her how to do that. There are emergency wavelengths and standard channels for warning and-”

“Yes, please, just do it.” Lonnie cuts Copy-Kyle before he can waste a probably-completely-good explanation on her. “Snip, get him and the three others here when he’s done.”

“I’m not going.” replies Copy-Kyle without hesitation.

“What?”

“I’m coming back on Etheria with you.”

“The offer wasn’t meant for you…”

“Entrapta said it’s okay? That’s why she gave me one of these fancy comm earpieces, by the way.”

Lonnie takes a deep breath. ‘Of course she did.’ Catra is smirking in a very *welcome to the Princess Club* way, Entrapta starts to explain how she can use him for her science stuff, and Adora giggles as she seems to finally calm down, when also Elena leaves the room with her team first.

Without the need to wait, Snip arrives two minutes later with Bob’s three remaining men at the point of his energy beam rifle. They look pretty frightened and by the few words that come out of their mouths, it seems that Entrapta threatened them with hair and tools when they came to, probably not on purpose. They steel themselves somewhat when they arrive in front of Bob, and a little of his grumbling later, joined by the last one who was hiding beside Miriann, they grab their own still unconscious people and walk away too. The sudden lack of action feels pretty weird for almost everyone but there is nothing to do about it. The Etherians slowly stand up and leave the cover of their crates in silence.

Until Miriann’s trackpad beeps, and an instant later with the help of Entrapta, surveillance cameras’ footages are displayed and they can confirm both Bob and Elena’s entire crews boarding their ships and taking off.

Now that everything seems resolved, Catra suddenly jumps and rushes through the crowd of inactive bots. Lonnie looks at her questioningly, then at Adora who shrugs clueless too, therefore everyone follows the feline girl, even if a little more slowly.

“We’re not going to call you Copy-Kyle, so what’s your name?” asks Lonnie as they walk.

“Ydren. Nice to meet you all, I guess?” He laughs a little nervously.

“You sure about this?” It’s a little late to ask, in fact, but Lonnie feels like she has to confirm once more. She wasn’t really at ease with bringing back the other captains, but *him*, it feels more like he should be the one less comfortable with the situation.

"Yeah. I'm dead anyway without the money from this job. I owe some people. Shouldn't look for me here."

"Great, and if they do come?"

"I'll work in exchange for asylum?"

"Fair enough for me, but you'll have to convince the head of the Princess Alliance." Lonnie winces. She really doesn't want to explain everything about Etheria's politic right now. "Don't ask, we'll talk about all that later."

The group arrives near Catra, who is looking at a few heavy assault bots. They are mostly intact, mostly, because they each have been shot expertly through their main control module or other critical spots.

"Someone's been having fun!" exclaims Silkya as she recognises Snip's work.

"More like, someone is actually doing their job *seriously*." Lonnie glares at her and gives a little appreciative nod to Snip.

"So that's your *magic*!" chuckles Catra. It should have been obvious but after Silkya and Miriann's crazy tales, she almost believed that Lonnie had gained magical powers.

"Yup." answers Lonnie simply. "I'm not as obsessed as you, but I do plan a bit ahead."

"I'm not obsessed!" hisses Catra.

"Adora on the other hand…"

"What? I came to help and-" intervenes the princess.

"Adora, you have a lot of qualities, but, even more so as She-Ra, *humility* isn't one of them, so let me give it to you straight." begins Lonnie. "You plan when it's pointless and you don't when

you should. You put my team in danger! You put Catra in danger, if that talks to you more. You shouldn't have come.”

“I did protect the team from the bots-” retorts Adora with a smug little smile.

“The bots you woke up, you mean? The situation was well under control until you showed up. You even put yourself in danger! If that weapon was made to deal with She-Ra, you could be seriously injured or even dead!”

“But-”

“No, Adora, you *were* useless. And that’s a good thing from time to time!” retorts Catra while she stands on tip-toe to pat She-Ra’s head.

“But... you...” Adora is strangely looking intently at Catra.

Catra looks at herself. She does have some scratches on her skin and clothes but Adora is certainly overreacting quite a lot and the feline girl returns her stare with one of irritation.

“Ow…” Adora lets a sad and embarrassed sound escape her lips and she looks like an abandoned little puppy despite She-Ra’s size.

“How did you even come here?” inquires Lonnie.

“I flew one of the other ships that Entrapta prepared. I didn’t need that much control to fly in space, and I stopped a safe distance from here and jumped?”

“So now there is a ship adrift out there to boot. Good. job.”

“Ah. Ahah...” Adora starts to laugh nervously. “I really messed up, hu…”

Lonnie simply nods, and everyone starts to walk back to the command room to join Entrapta and Ydren. Catra is staying very

close to She-Ra to comfort her since being told that she messed up seems to have taken her down way more than a bullet to the shoulder, and Silkya and Miriann are chatting and flirting as usual. Snip not-so-subtly comes closer and closer to Lonnie to complete the pairs, who looks at him, fairly annoyed for a second, and then sighs for the millionth time today. The little man grins as he takes a proper distance again.

“How was your time with Adora?” Miriann asks Silkya a little louder than necessary, obviously not wanting to let an awkward heavy silence come down on the group.

“Dense. Like, super duper dense.” replies Silkya dramatically. “I tried to flirt, but nothing touches her.”

“What?!” growls Catra.

“Don’t worry, she didn’t get any hints. Didn’t even manage to make her blush 'cause she didn’t understand.” Silkya shrugs while her face harbours a little smug grin.

“Wait, what?!” Adora joins Catra’s exclamation a little belatedly.

“Or maybe she just has a girlfriend already and didn’t want to answer you?!” retorts the feline girl.

“No. I think she is just dense.” confirms Silkya.

“Did- you... really…?” asks Adora nervously, and as She-Ra the effect is very much more visible.

“I mean, we talked about training, getting sweaty together and close contact. I asked to touch your *sweet muscles* and offered to compare the softness of our *hair* and things like that? I even mentioned swords and thrust. So yeah, I’m pretty confident that you are dumbly dense, but that’s kinda cute!” continues Silkya as she gives way more details than necessary.

“Aren’t you and Miriann together or something?” inquires Catra flatly, too stunned to stay properly angry.

“Yes, but this and that are different. After a few lives together, sometimes we agree that flirting with cute girls is okay! And since this life is more relaxed than the last few… Don’t worry, I wouldn’t have touched your Adora.” Silkya smirks again.

“Like I would have let you!!” hisses Catra once more in turn.

While the group is walking, otherwise peacefully, Silkya goes on with the story of what happened precisely since Adora joined her, and some more details about her vain attempts at flirting with the princess. To be honest, not much did happen except a few *bots slicing demonstrations* between the two to compare sword styles. Catra is still jealous and isn’t shy to voice it out but she quickly understands that she was somehow right. Adora is so smitten with her that she simply doesn’t even imagine someone else flirting with her and so the blonde girl ignores it unconsciously.

Somewhere on the way, Lonnie briefly stops to retrieve her hand cannon that she had dropped to be *captured* and soon they are reunited with Entrapta and a very nervous Ydren, since he understood, a little late, that the purple haired girl may not really have had the authority to invite him down to Etheria so easily. The young man even bows shortly to Lonnie and Catra when they pass in front of him, having now realised who are in charge.

He might very soon forget all of this however, the princesses not being *very* strict about hierarchical manners...

Wait and leave

While Entrapta, Ydren and Miriann work on securing the ship, its informations and secrets, the other people present don't really have anything to do, therefore they wait mostly in silence, each for their own reason. It reminds the ex-Horde soldiers of their cadets' time, standing by between exercises, awaiting new orders. Like in any kind of strict hierarchical organisation, people had to learn to simply wait.

They did gather whatever Bob's team left here in a single box first, but it felt more like they were trying to keep their hands occupied than a really purposeful task; both Catra and Adora were never any good at *waiting*. There are a few weapons but they don't really need those, maybe later for study, and everything else has been deemed *not cute enough* or *useless* by Entrapta.

She-Ra is still looking a little uncomfortable and she can't hide anymore, if she ever was able to, that Catra at her side helps. A lot. So they just stay close, but not too close to avoid unwelcome comments. Lonnie keeps her exemplary soldier's attitude and stands straight by the entrance, therefore Silkya and Snip feel obliged to do the same.

Miriann finally shows why she was chosen for this mission. In addition to her decent fighting skills and unpredictable magic, she is good with tech. *Bow's level* of good with tech, actually. Which is, of course, completely shadowed by the two people at her side being *absurdly* good with tech! But they still have tasks to give her nonetheless and they manage to work well together.

"Wouldn't it be safer to shut everything down?" wonders Catra aloud since all those preparations seem to take forever.

"Safer? How?" asks Entrapta back but she doesn't turn around and stays focused on her job.

"You tell me?" continues the feline girl.

"You mean letting the ship drift to solar wind and meteorites' impacts, or unpredicted gravity shifts, without control? It could come crash down on Etheria you know?"

'Well no, if I did know I wouldn't have asked…' Catra keeps her thought to herself, more as an attempt to not lengthen the wait by starting a pointless argument than anything else, but communicating with Entrapta is as frustrating as ever.

"Hey, did you know that those two have lived a few lives already?" Adora asks Catra excitedly as she points a finger at Silkya then Miriann, after noticing that her girlfriend is restless, or bored, maybe both. "I got curious when they said they have lived in another world because I thought I might find out things about where *I* came from and-"

"You believe their nonsense?" answers Catra curtly, yet she understands at the same time that she somehow got curious herself for the same reason. But the thought of Adora being interested by her origin, maybe wanting to be reunited with her *real* family, is a little scary.

Adora looks at her as if it is obvious. "I suddenly became She-Ra, my steed is a talking flying unicorn, and even *you* have a friend so magical that Entrapta has trouble explaining their powers, but you don't believe that those two might be special too?"

"Oh, for Melog I now have a few theories-" interrupts Entrapta but Catra doesn't let her end her sentence.

"Entrapta, please not now!"

"But…" The purple haired girl makes a very sad face, as only her knows how to, and a spark of regret surges into Catra's mind.

She has been trying to be a good friend to Entrapta lately, but unlike with Scorpia, even Perfuma does agree that the *understanding each other* part of their friendship would be tortuous even if they didn't have a complicated past. "I promise to listen to you later, okay?"

“Okay…” agrees the princess reluctantly. Putting science aside for later is always such a bummer for her but she knows that Catra doesn’t use the word *promise* lightly. Her *later* tends to be long however.

Catra faces Adora again and finds the princess making a very strange expression. Nowadays, the feline girl can usually brag that she understands her better than anybody, but not right this instant.

“It’s nothing, nothing.” answers Adora to Catra’s insistent gaze, and she tries to smile honestly.

But She-Ra’s face is still Adora’s face, and everyone knows that she can’t hide anything from showing on it, even if Catra doesn’t understand what it is. The feline girl continues to stare at her for a moment, yet she can’t bring herself to ask what Adora is thinking. Actually, it’s even harder to inquire when she is She-Ra, everyone’s princess, as if *not knowing* is the same as admitting that she isn’t more special and closer to Adora than the others right now.

“Oh, could it be you are jealous of Catra making a promise to another girl?” interprets Silkya as she harbours the mightiest of smirk.

“Eh? No- I- don’t- I…” stutters Adora, and she blushes. And when the embarrassment is strong enough to even make She-Ra’s stern face red to the tip of her ears, it usually means that the other person is right.

“You. I liked you better when you were an airhead. Were you just pretending?” hisses Catra to Silkya.

But while Silkya simply grins a little more widely, Miriann starts to laugh.

“What?!” erupts Catra.

“No, she is! An airhead. Only…” Miriann turns to face them and laughs harder. “She loves girl x girl romance soooo much that she never misses those things!”

The stupidity of what she just heard makes Catra flinch and she stares blankly at the short woman who doesn’t deny the claim. She proudly nods at it actually, and Catra has to put a lot of effort into keeping her calm. Out of her eye’s corner, she sees Miriann hastily turning her attention back to her task only to hide her own amusement, and Adora bursts out laughing too. At least the familiar sound helps Catra stay put but it still is very much annoying.

Instead of answering Catra’s hateful glare, Silkya takes a few steps away and starts to rummage through the box of outsiders’ leftovers, looking very closely at each weapons, inspecting their mechanisms and facture, as if she was a collector in search for a rare artefact. She has already chosen two of them and put her finds to the side when Miriann abruptly spins around again.

“No! Not this time! We agreed, no weapons’ hoarding!” objects the tall woman.

“Hey, but we aren’t stuck in a truck *this time*, why do you care?” retorts Silkya strongly.

It feels like there is a slight pause in time to Catra as her brain is playing a little trick on her. Curiosity. It is a strange thing… Once sparked, she knows she can’t simply ignore it. Adora at her side is already giggling again, having no trouble understanding what is going on inside her head. The feline girl rages. If not for her own reaction, she is pretty sure that Adora would be the one too curious to let it go, but she knows she has no chance when competing over who will manage to repress their curiosity longer. There are a lot of things at which Catra is better than Adora. A lot. But to her annoyance, this isn’t one of them.

She has always been curious and she can’t count how many times it caused her trouble in the past, because Adora found out early

and the blonde girl always tried to find ways to satisfy it, even when Catra was a scared and reluctant little thing, not big enough to ignore Shadow Weaver's threats, or try to, or pretend to... But she really doesn't want to think about this at the moment! "What now?" she asks forcibly to take her thoughts somewhere else, and the two other women's fantastic stories are at least good for that.

"Last time, I kinda piled up a few guns and Miri put a ban on amassing weapons..."

"*A few*, she said!" Miriann frowns. "We mostly lived in a little truck, with six people, and most of the space was taken by your fifty? sixty? weapons, all modified by this strange abnormal magic that was there and you just *had* to keep them all even if you only ever used two or three of them!"

"Well yeah, that's the point of collecting? To have it *if* you ever need it?"

"And the icing on the cake?" Miriann turns completely to Catra and Adora. "She was mostly punching things anyway! She had those weird earthy powers which reinforced her body so much that she was doing more damage with her fists! Thankfully she hates alcohol, *that Silk* drunk would have been a disaster for the furnitures!"

"I feel like there are a lot of things that you both said happened *last time*?" inquires Catra. She made them talk, she may as well commit to it fully.

"Well, we usually say *last time* to refer to one of our most recent lives, since we don't have clear memories of all of them and certainly not in a way that would tell us precisely in what order we went through them." explains Miriann.

"Even if we did, saying *the third-before-last live* would be a pain in the ass, to be honest!" adds Silkya.

"That's probably a fair point." notes Adora, now showing that she *is* interested and curious too since she already *won* when Catra

asked first.

“Whatever… so what happened?”

“We were moving around a lot, and so we had everything we needed packed in a little truck.” starts Silkya as expressively as always. “And the girl owning the truck didn’t let anyone else drive, so only one other person was comfy in the copilot seat, usually me since my armour was so bulky, while the four others were at the back, with loads and tons of stuff. And, maybe, four or five crates of weapons literally on their laps?” She laughs openly at the memory once more.

“Seems like a fun road trip.” notes Adora again when she sees that Miriann is smiling fondly despite what she said earlier.

“Too bad we don’t keep precise memories of how the science or magic works…” deplores Silkya. “Those explosive magic-enhanced rounds would have been nice against the Horde’s bots!”

“I thought you liked your sword better. I haven’t touched a gun since I got mine!” adds Adora after realising that she has always preferred melee weapons herself.

“Well yeah, can’t beat the classics!” Silkya knocks a knuckle on her sword. “But it’s always good to have options… Mine doesn’t shoot magic rainbows. Aaaanyway. New world, new rules! That’s how we don’t go crazy. This time I *sword*, and Miri does magic and tech.”

Catra sighs again. “Here we go, see? That’s why your story feels so fake! It’s too convenient to be real.”

“Hey, blame Miri, she is the one who got us in this *wonderful* mess of a situation!”

“You know you like it!” retorts Miriann sweetly.

“Of course I *like it*, even if unlike you I’m still shit-scared of dying for good!”

“I do fear to lose you though.” Miriann winks and blows a kiss in Silkya’s direction.

“Hurg, sappy much…” Silkya scorns at her, yet she *catches* the kiss in the air and presses it to her chest.

Lonnie clears her throat a little loudly to make Miriann turn her attention back to her task. With her curiosity satiated, for now at least, Catra focuses on Adora again. The princess is still She-Ra, which makes the feline girl somewhat uncomfortable but she can’t bring herself to ask about it yet again. There are things that princesses do, that She-Ra does, that don’t concern her. And she hates it but it is just how it is. That part of Adora isn’t hers alone.

“So you want to know where you come from?” she quietly asks instead.

“You don’t?” returns the princess.

“No? What good could it do to me? If I ever had people, they either abandoned me, or lost me or… That’s not the problem anyway…”

“I’m just curious, I guess. But I think I would like to have a family somewhere out there.”

“We aren’t talking about this right now!” hisses Catra suddenly at the idea of Adora having to chose between her and other people, as the blonde girl did in the past with Bow and Glimmer, and that didn’t go well at all.

“Okay?” answers Adora hesitantly.

“See? Told you, *dense*.” mumbles Silkya beside Catra.

But before Adora can protest, Entrapta announces that everything is done. While they aren’t particularly in a hurry, Lonnie commands everyone to quickly go back to the ship. There are still lots to discuss back in Bright Moon and a few reports to write, and she doesn’t want to spend the night on it if she can help it.

Entrapta always moves fast inside ships and other complicated structures anyway and everybody jogs after her.

“What about the ship that Adora took?” inquires the captain as they almost run along the corridors.

“Oh, I already sent him back in orbit to the other side of Etheria! I’m going to use him as a relay since he isn’t safe for people to fly-”

“What?! Adora, you knew about this?” erupts Catra.

“She said She-Ra was fine…” answers the princess defensively. “The ship is okay, only the air system doesn’t function properly.”

The feline girl starts to mumble something about She-Ra being always the one who’s fine whatever dangers are involved, but in this case it is pretty simple and safe, because She-Ra can breathe in the void of space, for a short time at least. She has already done it before and these days her transformation is stable enough not to worry about it.

“I thought it might be good to have complete detection and network coverage around Etheria, and the planet itself was forming a blind spot and-” starts Entrapta again, somewhat missing that it isn’t this point which Catra is contesting.

“Okay, okay. Just write the technical parts down in your report later please.” interrupts Lonnie to prevent another waste of a good scientific explanation.

They find Shyko waiting for them in front of the ship, sitting on a large branch he cut from the tree. He slowly stands up, slowly waves and also slowly greets them. There are crushed bots’ parts scattered everywhere in a display of violence and chaos. If she has to guess, Catra would bet that the minotaur used that same piece of wood on which he was seated as a weapon, a very big weapon putting Silkya’s to shame, and not *slowly* this time. That’s the only way to explain the mess.

In a few words, he confirms that the ship is intact and ready, and that the only events he had to deal with beside bots crushing was listening to all the excitement he missed through his earpiece. Somehow, it is not clear if he considers *not being part of it* to be a good thing or not, but in the middle of this scene of destruction, nobody wants to ask him anything too personal.

The weird feeling that started once the action stopped is still there, as if they forgot to do something, yet they know they didn't, and therefore they embark hastily to not think about it any further. For Catra though, it is more the desire to leave this place that hurries her, but she almost managed the stay without incident, she won't brood over it now that it's over. And there is another matter that requires her attention anyway.

"Why are you still She-Ra?" she finally asks when they take off and Adora is *still* giant and glowy.

Worries and sweets

Catra would very much like to be annoyed right now. Unfortunately, she can't because she's worried over everything else. Adora is making excuses of imaginary threats, the mission still going on, hidden dangers that would require She-Ra's immediate protection and other things from that basket.

Usually it works like a charm to annoy Catra, but it doesn't at the moment because it's very clear that Adora doesn't believe her own words, which means she would rather risk Catra be angry than telling her the truth, which means this truth is bad enough to make her feline girlfriend seriously worry and Adora hopes to prevent it, which means she already failed because Catra is very much worried right now!

And since Catra is staying quiet instead of answering and arguing, Adora digs her own downfall with sillier and sillier excuses as she tries way too hard and she knows it. Catra simply waits for the princess to give up, arms crossed, tapping the tip of her foot impatiently on the floor, her claws clanging on the metal since she ditched the boots of her spacesuit as soon as she entered the ship, and she stares daggers at Adora whose voice gets quieter and quieter as the inevitable conclusion approaches.

Despite herself, Catra throws a questioning side glance at Silkya to see if the short woman has something to say about Adora's attitude this time again, but all she gets in response is a shrug. She notices then that everyone has joined her in staring and waiting for Adora to stop embarrassing herself, with irritated expressions on their faces, except for Snip who simply doesn't seem to care and Shyko who feigns to be focused on his piloting, but even Entrapta and Ydren who is a complete outsider look like they want to tell Adora to just drop it already.

After an awkward moment of silence, Adora finally turns back to her simple self. At first, nothing seems to be wrong, until Silkya

can’t bare the silence anymore. “See? ‘t wasn’t that hard!” she exclaims playfully as she slaps the princess’ shoulder.

Adora grunts loudly and drops on the floor, barely caught by Catra, thanks to the feline girl’s keen reflexes because she really didn’t expect that fall. But while she appreciates the excuse to have Adora in her arms, she really hates that her worries were not even close to this.

“I’m okay…”

Catra can’t help but frown as Adora seriously winces even though she is saying that, yet the feline girl’s embrace becomes sweeter despite her desire to hit the princess on the head. She should be angry and yelling but all she really wants right now is to hold her blonde idiot close. ‘Because, *love*, you know…’ Catra tries to justify in her mind. “Can’t you heal yourself with your almighty She-Ra?” she at least retorts sharply.

“It’s healed… I’m not lying when I say I’m okay, okay? ... but the pain will take some time to disappear. That’s just how it works-”

"That’s *okay*?! What’s wrong with your head! You should have been more careful in the first place anyway? Why are you always like this? Why can’t I be mad?!” retorts Catra again unable to put strength behind her words. “Did it hurt less as She-Ra?" she asks hesitantly, now even feeling a little guilty to have forced the princess to switch back if it means more pain for her.

"Yes-" Adora stops herself and sighs deeply. Tired of lying to Catra and aware that she can’t hide anything for long in her condition anyway, since she already isn’t good at it when she is perfectly fine, she corrects her answer before she embarrasses herself again. "No. Just easier to hide… Those things, *bullets*, pack a real punch." She manages a faint sheepish smile.

Catra bumps their forehead together lightly and sighs. She holds the princess closer and starts purring, because there’s nothing

else she can do for the pain, as well as grumbles and swears to admonish Adora later, because she won't let that one slide either.

At the cute sight, since Adora doesn't seem to lie when she says she'll be okay in time, Silkya starts to smile and flirt with Miriann beside her. Lonnie notices that they give off the same impression as Glimmer and Bow do. Even without any kind of physical contact or blatant display of affection, people around them simply *feel* that they are very close. And while the queen and her archer are very cautious to at least *appear* very proper, those two don't seem to care at all about what others may think of them.

And just now that makes Lonnie want to not care either. If Huntara was here, could she stop herself from brushing her arm, bumping her shoulder or patting her back? On the contrary, she feels like if Catra and Adora knew how slow they are taking things, the cute couple in front of her would make fun of it way more intently than if she was kissing Huntara right here, right now. And regarding the other idiot couple, as long as they obey orders on the job, she has already given up on making them behave. Moreover, today being so stressful, she certainly wouldn't mind a little bit of sweetness.

The thoughts must have shown on her face because Catra and Silkya are staring at her as they hold their partners in a more obvious manner. "Jealous, captain?" they scoff in sync. "We are already aboard a ship, we have some time to spare, you could have some of it too, you know? I'm sure *she* wouldn't mind seeing you for a bit." continues Catra as her smirk widens.

"We are still on a mission-" Lonnie freezes mid-sentence and the feline girl bursts out laughing, while Silkya tries very hard to not follow. The captain has to resign herself; she feels very much like she was about to take Adora's place in making empty excuses. She sighs, again, and the most frustrating thing is that she has to admit the suggestion would help a lot against those sighs. She hasn't seen her girlfriend for almost ten days. It doesn't seem like much. It shouldn't be much.

During the war, ten days away were as many opportunities to train and focus, or actions and dangers, and they always passed in a flash, but since then, days alone have been passing much more slowly; not that she is alone in the morning or evening anyway, but still, a different kind of *alone*. She *may* feel like she's becoming a tad spoiled in that regard if she's honest, having both a great *family* and an amazing lover.

However, not that long ago, Lonnie already decided to ignore Catra's attitude when she needed to start a new life, she won't pass a chance to have what she wants just to escape her mockery now. In addition, Catra technically has the authority to divert the *mission* somewhat. But it's still annoying when they all look at her like this.

"Moreover, it's still early, the job is done, quite successfully even, and Sparkles won't have time for us until evening." confirms Catra sweetly while Adora can't stop herself from grinning either, and Silkya literally has little stars in her eyes now, just as irritatingly as Bow often does too, but at least she manages to keep her mouth shut.

"I hate all of you." says Lonnie flatly after staring at each of them for half a second.

"Yeah, yeah, so? A little detour won't hurt."

"Can we? Can we? Can we?" Miriann jumps all over the place while Silkya nods insistently beside her. "We've never been there!"

"Fine, I guess, if everyone is okay with it, we can stop there for an hour-"

"I'm gonna nap anyway…" dismiss Snip quickly, a lot less enthusiastic than the others, as usual.

"I. do. not. care… much!" Contrary to the little man and the slowness of his own words, Shyko seems quite enthusiastic himself.

“Entrapta, you okay with it too?”

There is a little awkward silence as the princess apparently doesn’t understand what the discussion is about. “With what?” she replies hesitantly and a little embarrassed to have missed something.

“Are you okay with stopping by the Crimson Waste for an hour before going back?”

“Why do you want to go there?”

“Entrapta,” interrupts Catra. “Just answer the question, I’ll explain later.”

“I don’t mind going, but you always say *later*!”

Catra looks at her a little surprised at first. But it’s not wrong, and she promised herself and Scorpia that she would at least try. “Fine, come here and I’ll explain while we fly there.”

She begins to quietly spell out to the princess the meaning behind the previous exchange, with some exaggerations here and there to make fun of Lonnie obviously, loud enough to be sure that the captain hears all of it, and with a little help from Adora she stays mostly calm and doesn’t let her frustration get the better of her when she has to explain her own words in turn to Entrapta.

Lonnie grunts and turns around, very much decided to ignore Catra’s comments. “And you?” she asks the last of the people present.

There is another silence before Ydren realises that the question is meant for him. “Me?! You are... asking me?” he inquires hesitantly.

“Since you are here anyway.”

“Uuh, mm, yeah, but… I may have a little… *misjudge* the situation…”

“How so?”

“You know, I- thought… coming here was- easy and… safer than be... out there-” he stutters anxiously.

“Why are you so nervous? I don’t plan on threatening you again, but if you act all that suspect... You have something to hide?”

“No, no! Nothing of the sort!!” Ydren takes a deep breath. “I thought you were a bunch of rebels, or adventurers that got crazy lucky and found a way to take care of Prime by chance... but since I got onboard, I’ve heard things about kingdoms, princesses and now I’m supposed to present myself before a Queen?! I’m not ready for that!”

Lonnie puts a reassuring hand on his shoulder. “Yeah, no. You don’t have to worry-”

“Oh yeah, you should be worried! Our queen is horrible!” retorts Catra with a big fang-showing smirk as she stands up and approaches menacingly, making for a funny contrast between her words, her face and her actions. “She always manages to get her way, she can talk you into doing things you really hate easily, and her magical powers are sooooo… hurrrg.” She holds her hands up in dramatically-fake despair and rolls her eyes. “And she’s *never* wrong! Don’t ever say you’ll do *anything* for her, because she *will* take it literally!“

“Catra!!” Adora jumps up, as much as she can without hurting her shoulder too much.

“Whaaaat, it’s mostly true?” replies the feline girl sweetly.

“Well, partly... But no, no! Don’t give him weird ideas! Glimmer is the kindest person in the world!”

“Sure… Should I not tell him that she even beat up her own dad?” Catra can’t stay serious and she is almost laughing by the end of her sentence. Adora looks stuck between joining her and wanting

to defend Glimmer, while Lonnie can't help but laugh a little too since she didn't expect Catra to throw that one out here.

Ydren laughs nervously and takes his head in a hand, suddenly wondering why he even thought that those people could be serious. It's been only a few hours since he met them, and already the gulf between their attitude and what they accomplished, both on the Velvet Glove earlier and in the war with Prime, seems ridiculously huge, even if he still has doubts on the latter part.

Lonnie sighs. She promises herself it's the last time today. A messages' exchange with Huntara, a quick order and a few minutes of flight later, they land not far from the newly built *Crimson Waste Embassy*. Princess Alliance's request.

"You better be back on the ship in an hour or I leave you here! Silkya, don't make me order you to run back to Bright Moon on foot!!"

Happy hour

Despite his lack of motivation, Snip volunteers to keep an eye on the ship since he doesn't plan to go anywhere anyway. Unlike most of the kingdoms, the Crimson Waste doesn't really have guards. There are a bunch of clans that *officially* keep the peace and order, but with the value of a ship like that, they may have to pay to retrieve it in one piece after their errands.

Miriann is the first out, followed by Silkya pushing a nervous Ydren in front of her. Entrapta comes behind, hesitantly. This part of the Waste is brimming with life and being surrounded by so many people isn't really her thing. It could be a good opportunity for her *social interaction study* but she hasn't yet switch to that mindset. Lonnie calmly walks down the ramp, but as soon as she thinks she is out of view, she starts running to the building.

Since this *embassy* has been built, a lot of people have come to set up shops and inns, taverns and attractions in the neighbourhood, and all the streets visible from here are very lively. In fact the whole place looks like an enormous marketplace rather than a diplomatic district. It seems the only rules are that nobody builds anything within twenty meters from the embassy's perimeters and nothing higher than its main building.

Adora and Catra leave the ship last. They are walking a little more slowly because of Adora's injury but the princess seems to be better already. And not just pretending this time. They don't have anything to do at the moment, therefore she doesn't have any excuse to try to ignore it either. Each steps still make her shoulder sting and Catra is glaring at her frequently as to command her to slow down if it hurts.

After a few seconds, Adora realises that they didn't make any actual plan. Lonnie had a precise goal and the first group just went off in a random direction led by Miriann, but Catra and her aren't really used to do *random* things. '*Anymore*'. She adds to herself, because when she was young, she definitely was dragging

Catra in all kind of expeditions that weren't planned at all. She misses it dearly when she thinks about it, but this is not something she can simply switch back to.

"Where are we going?" asks Catra first.

"Dunno. I haven't seen Huntara since the party but-"

"We are *not* going in there *too*."

"Uh… yeah, I know?"

"With you being so dense and all…" Catra's eyes drift to the side and she can't help complicated feelings making her wince anxiously. Adora's obliviousness isn't a problem, it's even usually cute if Catra is honest, but it can cause some *jealousy* issues that Adora has trouble seeing by herself.

"Not so much that I would get between them when I can come say hello whenever I-… *want*… Okay, I might have thought about it… Fine… I thought about it, but then I imagined *what if that was Glimmer visiting Bow*, and she wouldn't mind me coming along, yet she would glare at me like she is happy but not *that* happy…" Adora pauses and takes a deep breath when she notices two heterochromatic eyes scowling at her, annoyed again.

Catra grumbles to herself. Despite her desire not to, she is clinging to Adora's arm, the healthy one, as if she is scared that the princess will fly away to play the hero somewhere else if she lets go. It's irrational, she knows it perfectly, yet it sticks. "What about me?" Her voice is so muffled that it's almost a whisper.

"What? What about *what about you*?" asks back Adora with a little grin on her face.

"Don't *what what* me, you idiot!"

Adora chuckles a little at that retort. She wasn't trying to make Catra angry but little exchanges like this remind her of the good part of their past; their complicity, silent understandings and

simply how close they were. And now after three years it's all coming back to be part of the present too, and despite her girlfriend's grumbling, she knows that Catra is thinking the same because the feline girl has a hard time trying to hide a little grin on her own.

Catra begrudgingly makes her point clearer. "If I was visiting you, you wouldn't mind people tagging along?"

Adora stops walking and freezes entirely. "Uh... mm… that… depends on what- we... planned to do?" she stutters then. There are a lot of proper but private memories coming to her mind, and also a few less proper ones.

Catra bursts out laughing at Adora's sudden awkwardness. "That's the point! Without plan, well, without *you* knowing the plan at least!"

"Oh. Alright, we definitely *aren't* following Lonnie."

"Now I kinda want to, just to see Huntara's face when we barge in unannounced!" Catra laughs again.

Adora laughs with her this time but the princess' eyes are clearly asking 'You're not serious, right?!' nonetheless, which makes Catra laugh even harder. After a few random steps under the afternoon sun, the feline girl's shoulders suddenly drop.

"Let's find shelter and something to drink, I had forgotten how hot it is here!"

Lonnie stops running when she enters the embassy, takes a deep breath and arranges her hair. She usually doesn't really care about how her dreadlocks are tied, as long as they don't get in her way, but Glimmer just had to be there one day when Lonnie particularly didn't care.

Of course again, the queen had to talk about it, not harshly, with her usual kind attitude, but also with her air that if she cares about it, the *whole world* should care about it! But despite being very annoying, that also made Lonnie kind of conscious about it, and while she still usually doesn't care that much, there are people in front of who she wants to appear particularly good.

One of those is waiting for her on the other side of the door she is reaching for, in fact.

"Hi Hunty', nice to see you!"

"Hey Lonn'! Welcome!"

Despite both having their own trackpad now, since Huntara isn't fond of that type of communication, they always have a lot of catching up to do when they see each other like this after a few busy days. And today has been eventful to say the least. Therefore after a couple of kisses and tender words, they both narrate their best stories and time flies away quickly.

"And that's how we ended up here!" Lonnie finishes the summary of the present day. "So, what now?"

"You are only staying an hour, right?" inquires Huntara.

"Well, half an hour now."

"I can imagine a few things we can do in half an hour…"

In the middle of that mess of a marketplace, after a short sightseeing tour, Miriann quickly spots a street with mostly clothes' shops and drags the group there. Despite the others' resistance, Silkya and her undertake the unnecessary task of finding new clothes for Ydren, who only brought one medium-sized bag with him on the ship, although saying that it is all he has but all he needs.

Eventually, the search for clothes spread to all four of them, and everyone's opinion is asked for everything. Ydren starts to second-guess his decision to come once more when he realises that Miriann only asks opinions for the sake of arguing against them, and Entrapta is completely lost in the middle of this, yet she is having a lot of fun analysing the two other women's interactions with him.

In those conditions, an hour is very short and soon they have to go back already, with a few full shopping bags that they would rather stuff inside the ship as soon as possible, preferably before Lonnie sees them...

Queen Glimmer is slightly vexed. The last meeting has been particularly dull, and in the middle, when she sneakily peeked at her trackpad, she noticed a non-urgent message from her team out in space. She certainly didn't read it instantly and kept listening attentively to one of her adviser who was talking about… something.

After learning that her friends were stopping by the Crimson Waste on their way back, she simply couldn't stay put anymore and did her best to shorten the meeting. She certainly, again, didn't make the most inappropriate excuse ever heard in an official meeting to do so. Or at least close to, since Catra once left her alone saying she had to go feed Netossa's cat or something like that.

What is irking the queen however, certainly, for the last time, isn't that she is missing on all the fun, again! On these important days, her duties are more than ever piling up and her presence is needed in Bright Moon, but today she is the only one, amongst her group of friends, stuck here. She sent Catra out in space hoping that it would be a nice change of pace, Bow is on an errand to another kingdom, Adora is… being She-Ra, and even Netossa and Spinnerella are back home at the moment.

And the queen is stuck- *was* stuck here, but now the meeting is over and she fortunately hasn't got any more urgent work to do since her next duty planned is a debriefing with the previously mentioned still-absent team. Which would have arrived perfectly on time if she didn't accelerate the last discussions. A fact that she is doing her best to ignore.

Glimmer quickly teleports to her room to grab her staff and get ready to leave. She is trying to think of it as a *one time* thing, but she couldn't help notice that neither her dad nor Juliet were fazed anymore when they received the order to "Please hold the fort while I take care of some urgent business!".

She takes a deep breath to not appear rushed, and teleports away.

It's only after she arrives, and even after she asks to see Huntara to the representative at the reception desk of the Crimson Waste Embassy that Glimmer realises *maybe* the timing isn't appropriate and she *maybe* should have sent a message before coming unannounced like this. But before she can tell the person in front of her that she changed her mind, she is asked to follow them.

"Are you sure it's alright?" asks Glimmer when they pass in front of the main meeting room's door without stopping. As leader of the Princess Alliance and representative of Bright Moon, she was present for the inauguration of the building and therefore she knows the place a little.

"Huntara didn't give any order not to be disturbed, so yes, but you know her, please don't take offence if she's nonetheless busy. She is with another guest."

"Only one guest?" inquires the queen, intrigued and more and more worried of interrupting something.

"Should there be more?"

"I don't know, maybe I should really-"

Glimmer can't finish her sentence because, as her company opens a door leading to a training ground behind the building, she is suddenly stunned by what she sees, even if a little reassured too. Lonnie and Huntara are here, sparring with combat staves. Glimmer blinks. While happy to not have interrupted any other *activities*, she is beginning to worry about this relationship. In other circumstances, she would think that the two women are only pretending to train, but they are completely equipped for it, from protective gears to weapons.

"Hey, Glimmer, what are you doing here?" asks Lonnie before the queen can speak again.

"That's my line?!" explodes the queen.

"Oh come on, we were done early and-"

"That's not the issue!" Glimmer doesn't let her finish, but since all she gets are confused looks and raised eyebrows, she has to explain further. "You take an hour of free time alone with your girlfriend and all you find to do is combat training?"

"Coming from someone who took, like, ten *years* to even kiss her archer…" snickers Huntara.

"We weren't together at the time!" justifies the queen.

"Then pretend that we aren't either and mind your own business!" retorts Lonnie with a smile, used to Glimmer's attitude and resolved to stay positive for the rest of the day now.

"At least do something more fun!"

"But this *is* fun!"

"Sure is. I hope you didn't come here only to meddle with our relationship?" adds Huntara.

"No. I thought it could be nice to come say hello too, actually, not for official business for once. But I'm very busy, and I barely got

out of a mountain of work, and I finally-”

“Wouldn’t be so hard if you didn’t want to control everything in your kingdom. *I* have a ton of free time.” chuckles the Crimson Waste’s woman.

As Glimmer is about to answer, Lonnie stops them promptly. “No arguments about how differently you manage things please! *That* would be *not fun*. Anyway, it’s time to go. The hour is over in five minutes.”

Only then the couple starts to act sweet and flirty, and the queen has to dash out through the door first to not feel *now* that she is interrupting when they start to kiss, completely ignoring her presence. She almost instinctively teleported home, but that would be accepting that she came for nothing. She has to at least accompany them aboard the ship for the trip back to Bright Moon, right?

Kindly return

“That’s the queen?!”

Ydren didn’t mean to say it aloud, and most certainly not loud enough to be heard by the queen in question, but the surprise was just too much when Silkya told him while pointing a finger at her arriving with Lonnie and Huntara. Although once again, his action is met with laughters instead of hostility, very frankly from Silkya, a little more awkwardly from Entrapta and quite mockingly from Miriann.

But to his defence, while Glimmer has manners and a noble attitude, when she is joking and teasing her couple of friends beside her like this, it isn’t obvious that she is queen, to say the least. People respect her because she is fair and kind, and unless she starts using her offensive magical powers, which she tries not to as much as possible, nobody would ever say that they are afraid of her. To the point that even herself knows it, and makes sure that either Micah or Juliet are present when she needs to make a threatening first impression.

However, she didn’t plan to at the moment, because from the messages that Lonnie sent her, Ydren doesn’t seem to be a threat at all. Of course, she has already decided to keep him in Bright Moon for some time before she lets him run wild with Entrapta in one or other science project, and she certainly wants to prepare him a little before he meets the two Hordaks, but aside from that, if Entrapta thinks of him as a friend, that’s enough.

While Glimmer starts a friendly conversation with Ydren to reassure him, Lonnie looks around and checks the time on her trackpad. There is only one minute left before the deadline she set earlier. She would rather not be too biased about it, but Catra being tardy doesn’t seem like something unexpected.

“You’re going to make Adora run back too?” asks Silkya with a big grin on her face after easily guessing her captain’s thought.

“I don’t really care, she can just call her flying unicorn anyway…”

“A flying unicorn, right…” Ydren flinches. His logical brain is trying very hard to assure that it’s only a figure of speech but he doesn’t know what to believe anymore here.

“You know, you should stop being surprised by every little things or you won’t last long.”

“Like you did any better when *you* arrived in Bright Moon!” snickers Catra as she arrives, racing with Adora to make it just in time.

Shyko arrives calmly, slowly as usual in fact, but precisely at the last second too. With everyone here, some greetings and explanations take place while he prepares the ship for departure. Although Adora seems to be surprised by Glimmer’s presence, Catra isn’t, not even in the slightest. A fact that prevent the queen to say anything about the couple’s almost tardiness, or them holding hands, since an open argument may force her to justify why she is here. Which she can’t really without admitting that she was just bored and a teensy little bit jealous of missing out on the action.

Since she’s here anyway, the planned meeting is done on the ship’s bridge as they travel, and by the time they reach Bright Moon after a detour to drop Entrapta at her castle in Dryl, the only task left for the space squad is some cleaning and tidying up the ship. In addition, the queen, her first captain and intendant still need to officially write down a few reports and therefore the three of them head to the meeting room. When Lonnie finally leaves once everything is done, it’s dinner time already and she rushes out to not be home too late for it.

As Catra is about to stand up too, she hesitates a second and sits back. “Did you really have to send Adora? I mean, both Lonnie and I are kind of pissed, even if we decided not to write it down officially.”

“I didn’t?” asks back Sparkles questioningly.

Catra doesn’t expect the queen to lie and she seems genuinely surprised. But it doesn’t make much sense for Adora to appear up there unless she was sent to help. Although she can’t put it past Adora to have hijacked the second ship on her own either. But it was in Dryl therefore the queen has to have teleported her there at least, to arrive so quickly.

“She didn’t tell you?” asks Sparkles again since Catra is staying quiet.

“No?”

Glimmer sighs. She didn’t expect Adora to be too precise about it but at least a little obvious that she was afraid for Catra’s mental health. “She was so restless. She even yelled at me when I told her I sent you up there. I’m sorry, I didn’t think twice about what being in that place again may mean to you. I just thought it was a good opportunity for you to do something different. I know you are a little bored-”

“Hey, hey, I’ve been through much worse… I agreed to it. I would rather go back there than-”

“You shouldn’t have to choose the least worse between two bad options! Catra, you deserve to choose a good one too! I’m really sorry! I know what happened to you at the beginning of the mission. Adora was kind of right, I shouldn’t have sent you-”

“Who…?”

“Lonnie told me. She didn’t write it in her official report though. You know what this means for her so don’t be mad, please?”

“Grmpf… fine. It wasn’t *that* bad anyway, since…” Catra stares at Sparkles for a few seconds. The queen is looking back softly, kindly, as usual but with a little spark in her eyes as if she is following a plan about to succeed. “You want me to say that it wasn’t that bad because I wasn’t alone, right?” growls Catra.

Glimmer laughs. “I don’t know what you mean! Though I didn’t expect you to come back with more people than you left. And he seems to be quite attached to Entrapta already, that might complicate things with Hordak.”

“Yeah, but that’s a good thing.”

“Catra, I know you don’t like Hordak, but-”

“No, no, well yes, I hate him, but *that* has nothing to do with this? It-” Catra cuts herself. Glimmer is looking at her a little doubtful at first but then seems to accept that she isn’t lying. “Seriously, I have to teach *you* something about relationship?” Catra takes a deep breath. “Stars that feels good!”

“Come on, out with it already!” retorts Sparkles without hiding a little smile mixed with a moderately fair dose of frustration.

“You know, you seem to think that every friendship is so nice and good, but really, you are just lucky to have been able to choose real good ones.” Catra stands up and walks behind Glimmer’s chair slowly, as if not being eyes-to-eyes is adding weight to her words. And also to make Sparkles wait even more, of course. “But there are bad friendships too. You think back in the Horde I wanted to be friend with Scorpia? Surely not. But both of us had no choice. She was completely blinded by her admiration for me and felt rejected by everyone else, and I had no one else to turn to. She was the only one I could rely on, because she was the only one I knew wouldn’t betray me! Our relationship was nowhere near good. If anything, we hurt more than supported each other by a lot. And I mean a lot…”

Catra pauses briefly. Her voice started to shake by the end and she breathes slowly. She realises that there is one more reason making her stand here out of view from her friend and the fact that she unconsciously lied to herself and didn’t notice earlier frightens her. She knew where the discussion was going to go, yet completely disregarded what she would feel because of it, and the

tear running down her cheek makes the feeling impossible for her to ignore.

"But we had no choice!" she resumes before Sparkles can ask if she is okay, because the queen would surely have soon. "We had no one else. But we were both lonely, cold, we needed someone. We didn't have the luxury of searching the world for better friends even if we had wanted to. I'm afraid that Entrapta is doing the same with Hordak. And I don't want this to my f- friend! Back in the Horde, they both had no-one else either! She may still be stuck to Hordak because of this. We'll never be that close to her because of how she is with science, but if she has a choice, and still chooses him, then I think I might accept it… *him*, better. Because before Scorpia became the only option, I only had Adora too, and I still have, after I chose her and she chose me, so it doesn't *have to* end badly either… I don't know. Maybe Adora is influencing me and I'm thinking too much about it, or you are and I'm prying too much into Entrapta's stuff!"

Catra growls loudly. She wipes her tear quickly but the awkward silence that Sparkles isn't breaking compels her to finish. She takes another deep breath and goes on very quietly.

"I thought about it, you know… If Adora and you didn't get along at all, maybe Adora would have come back to me… I wanted you to be a horrible person… I hated you for being so nice. Then *everything* happened and… anyway, at least I could always choose if I wanted to be friend with you or not since the opposite didn't mean being all alone in the world, so it's good for Entrapta to have the same kind of choice, see? And… I love Adora, of course, but- mm, Sparkles? I'm glad you're here too."

Catra suddenly appears from behind the chair and hugs Glimmer from the side, clumsily, awkwardly, as if this is the first time in her life that she is hugging someone other than Adora, then just as suddenly she freezes and blushes furiously when she realises what she is doing, and dashes out of the room to run away as fast as she can, leaving her friend perplexed and amused, alone in the meeting room.

By the time Glimmer looks at the door, Catra is already nowhere to be seen and her soft steps are barely audible in the hallway despite her precipitation. The queen stays a moment without moving, contemplating what just happened and reflecting on Catra's words. Somewhere in the middle is something that scares her. All relationships are not meant to easily work. Some require a lot of effort. Some might not ever? Catra was right in saying she was lucky. She has Bow, Adora, and even Catra herself now, and a lot more friends with whom the difficult part of their relationship was never that they didn't get along.

And now she has to deal with a completely foreign outside universe, and its inhabitants who'll probably see the world very differently. She believes in her kindness but she also understands why the Horde was considering being kind or soft as weaknesses, enough to make it sound like an insult to them.

Unexpectedly, Melog appears at the door and enters quietly. They approach and put their head on Glimmer's knees in a reassuring manner. Their kind was also kind and soft, and now Melog might be the last one of them, yet despite everything they are still so tender and sweet. Glimmer rubs their head and scratches behind their ears. She has to become stronger to protect this, and Bright Moon with her. Melog starts to purr softly as her resolve strengthens, as if they agree and want to show their support.

The queen grabs some documents from the nearest pile and starts to read, her other hand still petting the big alien cat.

She can do it, she won't falter, and there is a lot of work to do.

Unending ending

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora is writing at her desk when suddenly a ball of fur rushes through the door, crosses the room and dives into the bed. She glances over her shoulder only to see two heterochromatic eyes looking back at her from under the cover, like an animal peeking out from the depth of its burrow. The princess muffles a little laugh and walks to sit on the bed, calmly, to not scare the cute little creature hiding in there.

"What's the matter?" But the only responses she gets are some hissing and growling. "Catra?" she asks more tenderly.

Since the feline girl still doesn't answer, Adora embraces the whole cover pile lightly. At the gentle contact, Catra straightens up and wiggles her head out of the cover to stare at her intensely. "I feel like I'm becoming all soft since I began living here."

"Yeah, you said that right after arriving too, if I remember correctly." Adora laughs a little at the memory.

Since confessing their love for each other, Catra had began to show softness around Adora, and not later than the same evening, the feline girl had already noticed how weird it felt. But until now, that softness was saved for Adora only. Almost, because on a few occasions she let herself cry in front of Sparkles too actually.

"What happened? Did Glimmer do something weird to you?"

"Yeah… rrmm, no... *I* did..." answers Catra hesitantly until she glances at Adora. "Hey, don't look at me like that, I only hugged her, okay?! She's fine, but I'm not! It's weird, I don't hug people!"

"Is it that bad?"

“Back in the Horde, you didn’t hug people either!”

“But that’s in the past… I think I rather like hugs actually, now that I got used to it. I felt weird too the first time Glimmer hugged me, trust me. But if you ask her, she’ll tell you that you *normally* want to hug people when you like them-”

“I do not *like* her!”

Adora bursts out laughing. “Do you remember when you used to say that about me too?”

“Shut up! That is so unfair to bring up!”

“Yeah? Then you want to hug me?” Without waiting for an answer, Adora raises a hand to the back of Catra’s head and starts to gently stroke her hair and rub the base of her ears.

“Nooo… Maybe… When you are not too annoying.”

The princess simply grins and begins to fondle a little more strongly in a way she knows that Catra likes. There is a little grunt of annoyance and the feline girl somewhat glares at her for a second, but Catra also can’t stop herself from purring under Adora’s attentions. She lets the princess do as she pleases for a brief moment before growling and pulling away.

“Stop petting me!”

“I’m not petting you, I’m caressing you.”

Catra’s irritated face is quickly replaced by her most teasing fangs-showing smirk. “Are you inviting me, princess?” she says sweetly enough to crack Adora’s stoic attitude.

“Eh? Oh… no I didn’t mean- I mean… I just like touching you, it’s a step further than hugs, to tell how much I... Just for you, ’cause, you know, you’re *my* girlfriend and you don’t even hug *me*…” She mumbles the last part as if it is not meant to be heard yet impossible to keep to herself.

“Are you finally jealous of Sparkles?”

“No, no! You know I don’t mind you being close to her, but I still- sometimes… I have this sort of tightness in my chest- and kind of want to take you away from everyone, even her-”

“Adora. That’s exactly what jealousy is.”

In a swift motion, Catra leaves the bed cover and jumps to land sitting across Adora’s legs. She starts purring softly again and smiles at the blonde girl who immediately embraces her. Catra is looping her arms around Adora’s neck, when she suddenly jumps away and winces.

“See?! I’m doing it again! I’m okay *acting* a little bit soft around you, but earlier it was with Sparkles, who’s it going to be tomorrow, Hordak?!”

“Aren’t you a little too dramatic about it? You went through a lot of hardship with Glimmer, you two deserve to share some soft times too.”

“I’m not soft! Why are you okay with soft in the first place? Not so long ago you would have fought anyone calling you soft!”

“Perfuma made me admit that being a little soft isn’t so bad sometimes? Depending on when and who you are with? I don’t mind being called soft for you at least.”

Catra growls lowly. “I don’t want to be called soft *at all*.”

“Then toughen up and finally come train with me in the morning as you promised? I’m still waiting…”

“Yeah, that’s the plan, tomorrow.” Catra sits back on Adora’s legs. The princess puts an arm around her back immediately to support her as if it is the most natural thing in the world.

“Really?”

“Yes, but what’s the point in you training so hard if you are going to throw yourself at danger instead of fighting smart anyway?”

“You’re still mad about it?”

“Of course! I thought you were doing better, but apparently not? You think I didn’t notice you sidestepping in front of us when Elena drew out her gun? Do I need to remind you that I’m faster than you? And then you provoked her as if you are invincible!”

“There wasn’t just you. What about Lonnie and her recruits?”

“You saw them fight, right?”

“Uh, yeah, but… I don’t feel right just sitting there and-” Adora doesn’t finish her sentence because Catra has crossed her arms by now and is staring needles at her, furious and not afraid to show it. “Right. Sorr- ... I mean…”

For a long moment after that, the room is kept in a deep silence. Catra is the first to break it because she knows that her blonde girlfriend is unable to, but she hides her face in the crook of Adora’s neck and keeps her arms crossed to show that she is still angry despite her words. “Please don’t make me lose you again...”

Adora doesn’t answer. She holds Catra closer however. They have had this discussion a number of times already and she knows that she can’t promise not to play the hero again. As long as such situations happen, she knows that she will have to bear the weight of choosing who to protect. And the least she can do is not making excuses about it.

Another moment passes before a strong knock on the door surprises both of them.

“Lady Adora, lady Catra, I’ve got an urgent message for you.”

The two girl glances at each other. Since Catra has been appointed intendant, it’s not unusual for her to receive messages, even to their bedroom, and the same goes for She-Ra. But it’s

actually the first time that a message is meant for both of them, if not counting Glimmer's own still-frequent irruptions.

The letter they obtain from the messenger only contains a few short sentences. Apparently, the owner of the figurines' shop has finished his ensemble representing them that he was working on and wants to show the result to the models themselves before delivering it to the people who put the order.

Adora gets instantly all excited and drags Catra out by the hand, but as soon as they leave the castle grounds, she slows down and the whole thing turns into a lovers' evening walk. Adora is still holding Catra's hand, and she intertwined their fingers together. The feline girl is a little uncomfortable about it at first but she can't really oppose it, because while the gesture itself is new, this kind of mood has always existed somewhere between them.

A lot happened, good and bad, a lot has changed too, but this, this part of Adora that Catra has always wanted, this connection and love they always shared long before they became aware of it, this hasn't changed that much, if at all, and despite being rough from training and hardened by fights, Adora's hand feels infinitely soft. And that softness is undeniably good to Catra, however much a part of her still wants to deny it.

But in those moments, the other part is winning easily and before she knows it, Catra's tail is already around Adora's waist, pulling the princess closer regardless of how much it hinders their steps. Adora is blushing too and has to put some effort into not breaking the mood by teasing Catra for this open show of softness right after the previous discussion, but the last thing she wants is for her feline girlfriend to stop, therefore she remains silent and presses her side a little more against Catra.

The only thing that puts some distance between them again as they enter the figurines' shop, after the owner deep slow laugh as he greets them, is Silkya's unexpected presence. "Hi there!"

“What are you doing here?” asks Catra a little annoyed to have the small woman spoil the moment by simply being there, since the feline girl didn’t want to deal with her after an already difficult time during the mission.

“Miri had a surprise made for me, and it happens that it has to do with both of you, so…”

“She’s the one who ordered this?!”

In display on the table in the middle of the room is a group of figurines that Catra and Adora only saw once and unfinished. The half dozen couples of *little them*, following each other on a miniature wooden path ornated by colourful flowers, represent meaningful stages of their relationship since they were little. But since last time they have been painted, accessorized and everything to make the figurines as faithful and *alive* as possible.

“Okay, I know what you think,” Silkya starts to explain as expressively as usual. “It might feel a little creepy to have unknown people using your lives as models-”

“No kidding! I thought it was Sparkles, or Bow, and even from them it felt weird!” retorts Catra instantly while Adora is politely smiling since she is used to being admired as She-Ra, but only half of those representations of her are as She-Ra and her smile strains a little when she realises.

“But look, to Miri and me, you are true heroes! And I mean both of you, not because you saved the world, we’ve done that enough ourselves, but because you went through all this, and still managed to end up together. I know I’m barely thirty to you right now, but believe me, I’ve got lifetimes of experiences, and you did good… you did really good, and you should be proud! And I want to remember this. Since I don’t need to hoard weapons this time around, because apparently we don’t have to save the world, I started to collect figurines of princesses instead, and Miri has made fun of me a whole lot since I began, but then she ordered this for me nonetheless-”

“Where is she by the way?” interrupts Catra. She doesn’t really care but Silkya was looking like she was going to talk all night long if not stopped.

“Oh, cleaning duty.”

“You said you collect those kind of figurines, but you didn’t even know what I look like as She-Ra?” intervenes Adora, brimming with curiosity.

“Yeah, sorry about that, the shop I was used to go to in our previous kingdom was a little behind its time and didn’t have any of your She-Ra. People took their time to believe that She-Ra was real, to be honest, and then Prime’s invasion put a stop to most non-essential crafts.”

“I also wanted to ask…” continues the princess. “do you think it’s possible that I come from another life too? I mean I know I come from somewhere else but maybe-”

“You really believe this nonsense?” interrupts Catra again, glaring at Adora, yet still holding her hand.

“Why not? She knows so much and in so much details? It feels true to me.”

“Well, usually we stay pretty quiet about it,” explains Silkya. “Because people tend to think we are crazy otherwise, but we decided to open up this time since Catra was interested!”

“I wasn’t-”

“Yeah, yeah, I know you only asked because you thought that if we came from another world, you might find some clues about your origins since it could explain the fact that you are unique.” Silkya smirks. “You are more obvious than you think, C-atra.” She lets the first sound hang in the air an instant, long enough to lure Catra into thinking that she was going to call her something else.

"And *you* are more annoying that you think too! I'm beating the crap out of you during training tomorrow morning!"

"Ow, too bad, I intended to sleep in tomorrow."

"So you give up? Scared?"

"Not a chance, but I had a few lives to train against such cheap provocations, thanks to Miri! I wouldn't mind fighting She-Ra though, seems like a fun challenge!" Silkya's smirk widens for a second, before her face turns all serious again. "But no. Miri and I are bound by a very special and specific spell, and I don't think it is the case for either of you. Though if you start having flashbacks of events from another life, I might revise my assessment!" Her grin is back and Adora almost laughs, while Catra is a little stuck between appreciating the silly lightness of her answer and being irritated by her provocative attitude.

The shop owner comes back with a large box and puts his work safely inside after confirming that the three women have seen enough for now. Adora's growling stomach also suddenly reminds everyone that it's getting late and they haven't eaten. In any cases, Adora and Catra know now that they can ask Silkya to see their figurines again since they have not been shipped to an unknown person… but they have no idea if they will ever want to at the moment.

They walk back to the castle still holding hands, a little faster now that they have realised they are in fact both very hungry after this long day. There are a lot of heavy stuff still weighing on them but if they have learnt one thing recently, it's to not try to solve everything at once, therefore their present concern is simply finding Glimmer to have dinner, because the queen is most likely still working, having forgotten the time too since her archer isn't here today to keep an eye on her.

"I'm home"

Lonnie's greeting is answered by her two men's and a nice smell coming from the kitchen. Before she can say anything, Rogelio makes her sit and starts to massage her shoulders, explaining that Huntara sent a message earlier saying that Lonnie seemed to need it.

"Stressful day?" he asks quietly.

"Yeah. You?"

"Same as usual. Some tensions with the new neighbours but nothing serious. I think they are scared of me though, so they keep quiet."

"Well, for Bright Moon's citizens we are still-"

"No, the Horde ones!" The lizard man laughs wholeheartedly. "We are kind of famous since people think we helped save the world and all, and we are friend with She-Ra and the queen, and *unfortunately* they wouldn't understand *if* I was to deny it, so… It might not be the healthiest kind of respect but at least it's peaceful for now."

Kyle soon arrives with the food and sets the table. Nothing fancy, just a normal proper meal to share between this family. Lonnie smiles. Away form the castle's grandeurs and its sumptuous hallways, away from the showy queen and princesses, away from advanced ships and tech, away from the rich banquets and magnificent ballrooms, those simple things are the best kind of luxury.

Chapter End Notes

Hi there,
I hope you enjoyed reading this as much as I liked writing it!

BONUS: Summary and characters ' sheet

Hi there!

I added a short summary and few informations about my original characters in the beginning of the second part of the ESDF's story!
Check it out!
I hope you'll enjoy as well!

Skyinou

End Notes

Thanks for reading! All my She-Ra works are part of the same big story, check my main series's description for more informations!

Please do share your thoughts! Comments are always welcome! Kudos too!
You can also find me on Discord to discuss, make suggestions or simply be notified when I post a new chapter!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!